



KANSAS EMPLOYMENT FIRST PROJECT

Kansas Employment First Policy Analysis and Recommendations: Final Report

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In 2011, Kansas passed the Employment First Initiative Act that requires competitive integrated employment (CIE) to be the first option when serving people with a disability. However, stakeholder reports note that progress has been slow, and available data suggest limited growth in employment services.

To support the implementation of the Kansas Employment First Initiative Act, the Kansas University Center on Disabilities (KUCD), in partnership with the Institute for Health and Disability Policy Studies (IHDPs) at the University of Kansas, engaged the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston (ICI) to conduct policy analysis and develop actionable recommendations. ICI used the Higher Performing States framework to guide a systematic review and analysis of reports and recommendations, policy and practice documents, and data from interviews with key stakeholders. Key themes and recommendations that emerged from the analysis include:

Leadership: Identify a lead entity that convenes state partners and guides the development of goals, implementation plans, and accountability structures. Consider a stronger role for the state's Employment First Oversight Commission. Currently, the Commission lacks authority and the ability to set goals and objectives. The Commission would benefit from a direct relationship to leadership, such as through the Governor's Subcabinet on Disability. Additionally, strengthening state agency messaging and oversight about employment outcomes can provide a unified message and support accountability.

Goals and policies: Establish clear goals that address employment. There are not established goals within agencies or statewide that address employment. Many respondents emphasized the need to review and update state policies and procedures, including Medicaid Home and Community-Based Services (HCBS) Waiver service definitions and guidance, to better reflect Employment First as a priority.

Funding: Address the role of tiers and staff ratios in funding. Currently, there is limited guidance about the relationship between funding tiers and staff ratios. This makes it difficult to assess the relationship of rates to costs across services.

Even with the current plans for rate adjustment, supported employment is funded at a significantly lower rate per staff hour than facility-based services, creating a significant disincentive to providers to expand employment supports. Develop clear definitions of allowable billable services under the new employment rate and implement rewards and incentives for providers to achieve CIE for individuals with disabilities.



The ability to access HCBS Waiver services rapidly when individuals transition from VR services to long-term follow-along services is a strong pro-employment policy. Opportunities to expand rapid access to employment should be considered, including sustaining employment as individuals exit education services and developing a limited waiver that supports employment.

Interagency collaboration: Improve service coordination and use of universal language. Many people with disabilities work with a variety of agencies that use different processes, procedures and terminology. Continue to expand efforts to emphasize employment in the transition from school to adulthood through the transition systems change initiative. All partners, including individuals and families, would benefit from a collaborative flow chart that maps employment supports across state agencies and populations.

Training and technical assistance: Develop a robust infrastructure for capacity building that includes training for employment support professionals and implementation supports such as mentoring and technical assistance that support implementation of best practices. Establish Kansas-specific training models that are built upon over time. Currently, most training is from third party entities. A lack of commitment to one training model may create inconsistencies across the state. Embracing person-centered and strengths-based training models (such as Charting the LifeCourse) as a consistent training path should be part of improving training direct service staff on employment. Training is needed within the education system as well so that transition staff understand the importance of Employment First and working in the community.

Data collection and performance measurement: The state has limited system or capacity to track data on employment outcomes and services; investment in this area is critical. Pockets of innovation in developing and using data exist: Down Syndrome Innovations is very data driven and provides an excellent example of a comprehensive data system that includes data on key variables and performance measures to guide future actions.

Services and service innovation: The system of support within and across agencies is complex and can be difficult for stakeholders to navigate. This includes the current structure of case management, which was described as “fragmented.” Some pockets of innovation have sprung from employment-focused investments, but they are challenging to bring to scale because of the complex infrastructure of the service system.

Engagement of families and self-advocates: There are challenges with respect to messaging to families from providers and state agencies about the importance of work as the preferred outcome. There is a need for greater emphasis on: the benefits of working, high expectations for people with disabilities to make meaningful contributions to their communities, and the potentially negative effects of segregated settings. This signals the values the system conveys to families and individuals. Family members discussed two key issues: (1) frustrations with staff turnover, especially at the case manager level; and (2) the complexity of navigating services. Adding employment as a goal can seem like an additional stressor to an already challenging service experience. Self-advocates, while a strong voice, need better support to be involved in systems change.

Attention to the needs of underserved populations: Develop innovative strategies to increase access to services for people with disabilities living in rural areas, people of color with disabilities and immigrant populations whose first language is not English, and people with disabilities in correctional facilities. These three groups were identified as underserved. Most key informants reported a lack of adequate effort to promote equitable employment opportunities and outcomes for these underserved groups of people.

After review of an interim report based on the aforementioned themes, members of the Kansas Employment First Steering Committee were invited to volunteer or were nominated to join a Working Group to identify the most impactful recommendations for implementation. These meetings identified and prioritized actionable recommendations to improve employment outcomes for people with disabilities in Kansas. Eleven members representing a wide variety of key stakeholders, including state agencies, provider organizations, disability rights advocates, and self-advocacy organizations participated. The Working Group prioritized the following three recommendations: (1) establish an operational leadership group to complement the Governor's Subcabinet on Disability, (2) build employment as a focus in service planning and mapping processes across various systems, and (3) develop and implement a funding strategy for CIE that reflects evidence-based and best practices in employment, managed care, and interagency collaboration. This new operational leadership group will develop concrete action plans to guide implementation and ensure consistency and strategic investment across existing initiatives.

INTRODUCTION

In 2011, Kansas passed the Employment First Initiative Act that requires competitive integrated employment (CIE) to be the first option when serving people with a disability. This was one of the first state level laws prioritizing CIE in the United States. Since then, the state has worked to implement the Employment First Act,. Examples include the recent proposals to increase payment rates for supported employment services, activities to modernize the Intellectual/Developmental Disabilities (IDD) Community Support Waiver, and funding to support providers to transform their agencies and expand access to CIE. However, stakeholder reports note that progress has been slow, and available data suggest limited growth in employment services. Investment in employment supports continues to be a concern, and only 1% of funding for employment and day services is allocated toward integrated employment services for the state IDD agency in Kansas.

To support the implementation of the Kansas Employment First Initiative Act, the Kansas University Center on Disabilities (KUCD), in partnership with the Institute for Health and Disability Policy Studies (IHDPs) at the University of Kansas, engaged the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston (ICI) to conduct policy analysis and develop actionable recommendations. ICI used the Higher Performing States framework to guide a systematic review and analysis of reports and recommendations issued by the Kansas Employment First Oversight Commission (KEFOC), existing Kansas policy and practice documents from multiple state agencies, and other Kansas stakeholders. The project team conducted:

- » An analysis of KEFOC and other stakeholder reports
- » Semi-structured interviews with key Employment First stakeholders
- » Analysis of service and outcome data from various sources

The project reviewed a vast amount of information, with the goal of understanding the policy landscape that impacts the implementation of the Employment First law. This report presents detailed recommendations from the review. Prior to finalizing this report, a small working group composed of members of the Kansas Employment First Steering Committee prioritized the most important recommendations. A summary of prioritized recommendations is included in an accompanying report.

SECTION 1: THE NATIONAL ENVIRONMENT

Legislation and regulation governing Medicaid Home and Community-Based Services (HCBS), the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act of 2014 (WIOA), and settlement agreements between states and the US Department of Justice are clarifying federal intent and paving the way to supporting opportunities for people with disabilities to have meaningful jobs in their communities. State level policy and practice are an additional factor impacting employment services. States provide, fund, and monitor a wide range of services, including employment supports, facility-based options (prevocational services often based in sheltered workshops and non-work day habilitation programs), community integration services, and self-directed options for people with disabilities.

Employment First in Federal Legislation and Policies

In analyzing efforts at implementing the Employment First Act (here after referred to as The Act) in Kansas, it is important to understand the national context of employment supports for people with disabilities. Throughout the past decade, an array of legislation and policies have created a consistent federal intent that publicly funded employment services and supports should focus on meaningful jobs in the community.

Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services (CMS): A primary funder of employment services and supports for people with IDD in Kansas and nationally are Medicaid funds administered under Home and Community Based Services (HCBS). Guidance from CMS in 2011 and in the 2019 1915(c) Technical Guide make it clear that individual CIE is the preferred outcome of HCBS employment-related supports (CMS, 2011; 2014, p. 249; 2019, pp. 149-150).

The Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA): WIOA is the federal legislation that authorizes the public workforce developmental and public vocational rehabilitation (VR) systems. Passed in 2014, WIOA establishes “competitive integrated employment” as the optimal outcome of VR services (in Kansas, these are provided by Kansas Rehabilitation Services). WIOA defines CIE as full-time or part-time work at minimum wage or higher, with wages and benefits similar to those without disabilities performing the same work and fully integrated with co-workers without disabilities. WIOA increased the role of VR in transition planning from the education system to the adult service system through creation of pre-employment transition services (Pre-ETS) and placed new restrictions on the use of subminimum wage under 14(c) certificates.

US Department of Justice: In recent years, the US Department of Justice has initiated numerous legal actions in states related to access to integrated employment. For example, settlement agreements with Rhode Island in 2014 and Oregon in 2015 required the states to take action to ensure that employment is offered as a priority outcome, and to improve both participation in integrated employment and the quality of employment outcomes.

The Rise of Employment First Policies in States

In addition to federal initiatives, 39 states have adopted Employment First policies (Hoff, 2021). These policy commitments include executive orders, state agency policy statements, or legislation that prioritizes community employment for people with disabilities who receive publicly funded services. Employment First represents a commitment by a state that all working-age individuals with IDD: (a) are capable of performing work in typical integrated employment settings; (b) should receive, as a matter of state policy, employment-related services and supports as a priority over other facility-based and non-work day services; and (c) should be paid at minimum or prevailing wage rates (Kiernan et al., 2011; Rogan & Rinne, 2011).

Employment First policies are nationally recognized as a path toward greater community employment for people with IDD. They anchor a service delivery system, focusing funding, resource allocation, training, daily assistance, and the provision of residential supports on the overall objective of employment. This makes it easier for individuals receiving publicly financed supports to enter the workforce and become contributing members of society (Moseley, 2009).

SECTION 2: BASELINE DESCRIPTION OF CURRENT EMPLOYMENT SERVICES AND OUTCOMES IN KANSAS

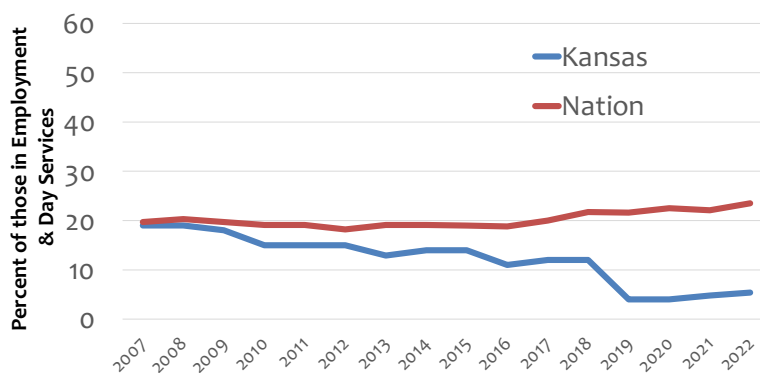
Kansas enacted the state's Employment First law in 2011 as a result of advocacy from a variety of stakeholders, including self-advocates, to advance legislation that would remove barriers to and prioritize community integrated employment.

Over the past 13 years, there have been numerous efforts to implement The Act. Some examples include the recent efforts to increase payment rates for supported employment services, activities to modernize and bring the IDD Community Support Waiver into compliance with federal expectations, and training and technical assistance to providers to increase access to services that lead to CIE. Other projects, investments, and entities in Kansas that are viewed by stakeholders as having a positive impact on implementation of The Act include: My Transition/My Career, Transition Transformations Coalition, Kansas Youth Transition Network (KYTN), Kathy's Bill, Kansas Works Youth Initiative, Working Healthy, the state's tax credit law, Project Search, KanCare, Self Advocacy Coalition of Kansas (SACK), and the employment program at Down Syndrome Innovations (DSI). Stakeholders in Kansas have also made use of national expertise available through the National Expansion of Employment Opportunities Network initiative (NEON) funded by the US Department of Labor, Office of Disability Employment Policy. Please refer to the *External Investments* grid in the appendix for a more detailed list of activities.

State agencies in Kansas are working to address the implementation of The Act as well as national level expectations related to CIE. In the adult service system, the areas of action have primarily occurred within three systems: (1) the IDD Waiver, (2) provision of services through the Kansas Rehabilitation Services, and (3) the administration of the Mental Health Block Grant. We examine data for these three systems to provide a snapshot of how Kansas' employment outcomes for people with disabilities reflect employment as the priority outcome.

Intellectual/Developmental Disability (IDD) Waiver. Recent policy revisions have focused on ensuring that Kansas is following the HCBS Final Settings Rule as well as the Employment First law. Despite this, in Kansas very few HCBS Waiver participants do receive integrated employment services, and the state continues to lag behind the national average and nearly every other state. The percentage of people with IDD who received an employment or day service and participated in integrated employment services in 2022 was 5.4%, lower than the national average of 23.5% (see Figure 1).

This data may not reflect all IDD Waiver participants who work in CIE but receive employment supports that may be billed under the day supports service. Data from the National Core Indicators (NCI) project suggest that the percentage of individuals who are working is higher than service data reflects. In the 2022–2023 data collection cycle, 16% of individuals surveyed in Kansas worked in an integrated job (individual job, group supported job, and/or a business in the community that primarily hires people with disabilities), and 14% worked in an individual integrated job. These percentages closely align with the NCI national averages of 17% in an integrated job and 14% in an individual integrated job.

Figure 1: Kansas Employment Data Snapshot**Percent in Integrated Employment Services**

Source: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agencies



In terms of financing, only 1% of funding from the state IDD agency is spent on integrated employment in Kansas. While nationally the average is also very low (10%), there are other states that support a much higher percentage of people in integrated employment services and use a higher percentage of their budgets to fund services that lead to CIE (Appendix B).

With respect to listening to people with IDD receiving services, 35% of people who are not working want a job; but only 15% of this group have a goal to get a job in their Individual Support Plans, reflecting gaps in case management (Appendix B).

Kansas Rehabilitation Services (KRS). KRS, like other state VR programs across the country, has continually worked to implement WIOA). For example, KRS collects robust data on services and outcomes as part of its reporting requirements to the Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA). In Program Year 2023, 3,210 individuals had closed KRS cases. While it is consistent with national trends, the number of closures has declined from 7,086 in 2013, a 55% decrease. Over the same period, the percent of all closures that successfully entered employment rose from 24% to 28%. Nationally, the percent of closures into employment was 31% in 2013 and 32% in 2023. Closures for individuals with an intellectual disability (ID) declined from 596 in 2013 to 326 in 2023, a 45% decrease, also consistent with national numbers. The percent of all closures for participants with an ID that successfully entered employment was 41% in both 2013 and 2024 and was higher than the nation as a whole (34% in 2013 and 36% in 2023). There has been steady growth in earnings for individuals closed into employment. Average weekly earnings have grown from \$300 in 2013 to \$441 in 2023 for all closures, and from \$173 in 2013 to \$221 in 2023 for participants with an ID.

Mental Health Block Grant. Data on outcomes are more limited from other programs and funding sources. Data from the FY2022 Mental Health Block Grant report suggests that 855 individuals participated in supported employment services through mental health centers and behavioral health clinics in Kansas, but data are not readily available on outcomes. KDHE maintains the STEPS (Supports and Training for Employing People Successfully) and WORK (Work Opportunities Reward Kansans) programs and supports a robust network of certified benefits planners. As of June 2024, 63 Medicaid members participated in STEPS, and 228 participated in the WORK program. Additionally, the Kansas IDEA State Performance Plan report for FFY2022 suggests that

statewide targets were not met for post-school outcomes for youth with individual education plans. Specifically, 56% achieved Indicator 14b (enrolled in higher education or competitively employed), versus a goal of 70%, and 68% achieved Indicator 14c (enrolled in higher education, other postsecondary education or training, competitively employed, or in other employment), versus a goal of 81%. Data on employment outcomes are not readily available from Kansas managed care organizations.

SECTION 3: SYSTEMS CHANGE RECOMMENDATIONS FOR ADVANCING EMPLOYMENT FIRST

States that have been successful in strengthening employment outcomes communicate employment as a priority across all elements of the system. Since 2007, ICI, in partnership with the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities, has used the Higher Performing States framework (Figure 2) to guide systems change to expand integrated employment in its work across the US. The model is based upon extensive research on states that serve high percentages of people with IDD in integrated employment (Hall et al., 2007; Winsor et al., 2023). It identifies seven elements of higher performing states (Table 1) and emphasizes that importance of each element on its own as well as in relationship to each other. Higher performing states maintain a consistent focus on employment in policy, procedure, and infrastructure within each of the elements (State Employment Leadership Network, 2020). In order for Kansas to fully implement the Employment First Act and ensure that CIE is the priority outcome of all services for people with disabilities in Kansas, the state must address each of these elements.

Figure 2: Higher Performing States Framework

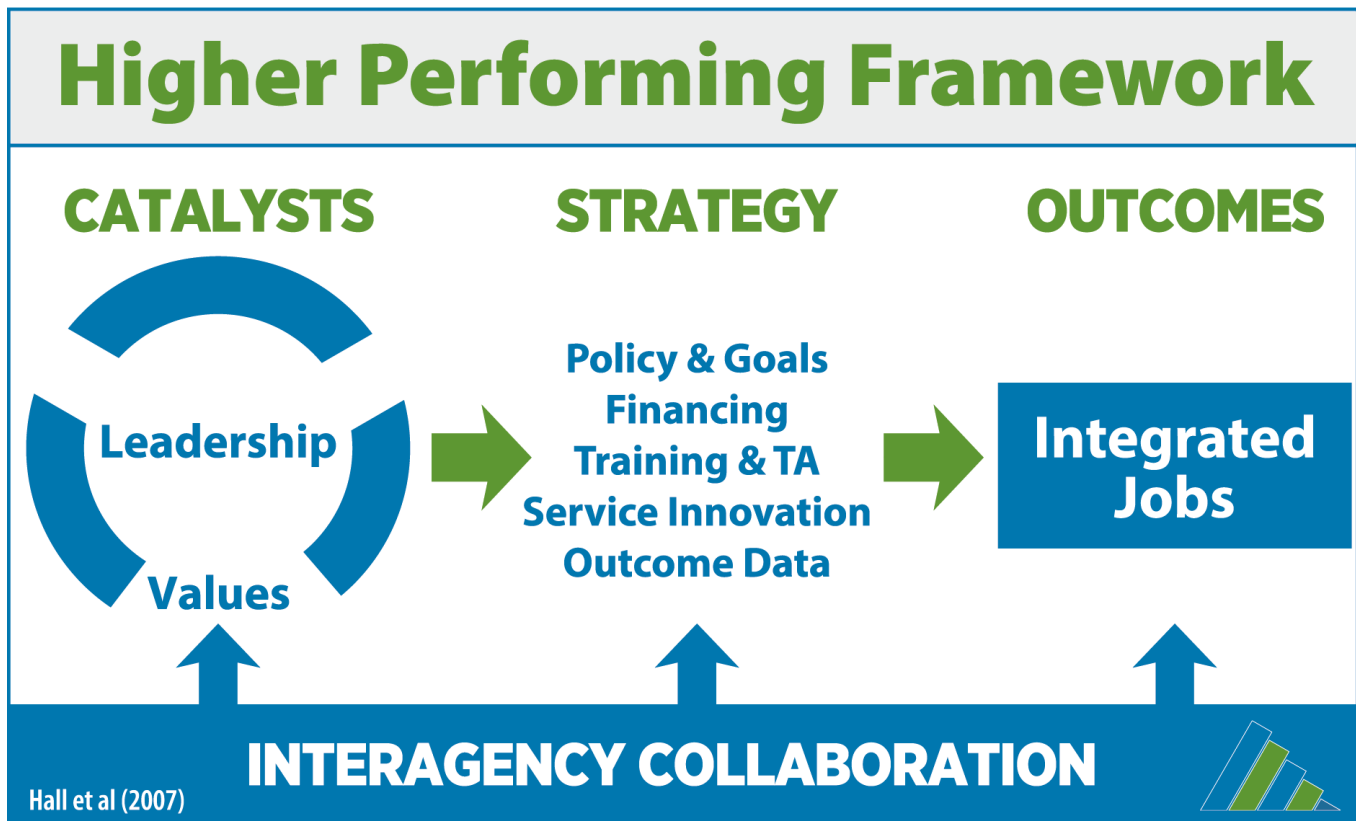


Table 1. Elements of High Performing States

Element	Description
Leadership and values	Leadership is defined as taking responsibility for the transition of youth and young adults with IDD from high school to CIE or postsecondary education, and for working-age adults with IDD from non-integrated employment services to CIE. Leadership is dispersed through the state, regional, and local agencies that play a role in the transition and employment of these groups.
Policy and goals	State and local agencies' goals and operating policies require and support CIE and postsecondary education as the first and preferred options in planning and service delivery for youth and working-age adults with IDD.
Financing and contracting	Funding strategies prioritize and support CIE and postsecondary education for transition-age youth and working-age young adults with IDD.
Capacity development/ training and technical assistance	There is a sustained and significant investment in education, training, and technical assistance to support statewide goals regarding the transition of youth and young adults with IDD from school to postsecondary education and CIE, and for working-age adults with IDD from non-integrated employment services to CIE. These investments are targeted at the staff of state agencies, schools and providers, youth and young adults, their families, and employers.
Interagency collaboration	There is a shared statewide intra-agency and interagency responsibility and authority for coordinating transition services and achieving CIE of youth and working-age adults with IDD. This collaboration draws on the participation of a broad consortium of stakeholders across the state. Collaborating public agencies should at a minimum include state and local education, VR, workforce, IDD, and Medicaid agencies.
Service innovation	State agencies create opportunities for schools, providers, youth, and working-age adults with IDD and their families to use best practices and creatively develop supports for transitioning to postsecondary education and CIE.
Performance measurement and outcome data	State agencies share data on service delivery and employment outcomes for youth and working-age adults with IDD. This data is used to track progress and support state agencies and policymakers in developing policies and procedures.

These elements provide a useful lens through which to understand Kansas's progress around Employment First as well as strategies to target for prioritization.

ICI used the High Performing States framework to guide the review of Employment First policy in Kansas and the development of actionable recommendations. In addition, based on feedback from the project's Steering Committee, we have added a focus on engagement of culturally diverse communities as an area of study, as well as efforts to engage individuals with disabilities and their families. Inclusion of these elements has also been recommended in the literature on higher performing states in integrated employment (Butterworth et al., 2023; Winsor et al., 2023).

Sources of data for the project included reports and recommendations issued by KEFOC and other Kansas stakeholders since the passage of the Employment First Initiative Act (e.g., formal reports, working documents, and meeting presentations and minutes) and semi-structured interviews (Appendix for the interview protocol) with 30 stakeholders including KEFOC, state agency representatives, provider agencies, self-advocates, families and advocacy organizations, and other Employment First stakeholders.

Also as described in Section 2 and Appendix, ICI analyzed service and outcome data from the following sources: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agency Employment and Day Services, National Core Indicators – IDD & Aging and Disabilities (NCI), Rehabilitation Services Administration – 911 (RSA), American Community Survey (ACS), US Department of Labor (USDOL), and Social Security Administration (SSA) to describe the employment services and outcomes in Kansas and compare them to services and outcomes at the national level.

1. Leadership

There is not currently a clear organizing or leadership entity within state government that holds responsibility for coordinating Kansas Employment First efforts. In the past, respondents noted that the Governor’s Subcabinet on Disability served as a central place for oversight and management of Employment First efforts. While respondents in the key informant interviews broadly agreed on the importance of advancing Employment First, they could not identify clear accountability pathways or champions that sustain long-term employment-related efforts. Respondents identified a need to strengthen engagement at the legislative level and ensure broad support across that policy-making body.

Many respondents agreed that the Kansas Employment First Oversight Commission (KEFOC) should play a stronger role in implementation and accountability. The Commission develops a comprehensive report annually, making recommendations to the governor, legislature, and state agencies on strategies to increase the number of Kansans with disabilities in CIE. However, because the KEFOC has no direct authority around implementation, “there is not yet a comprehensive and coordinated effort within Kansas state government that can ensure needed energy and resources are being dedicated to the goal of improving employment outcomes for Kansans with disabilities.” (Employment Systems Change Coalition report, 2018). KEFOC recently recommended a change in law or Governor’s Executive Order to restore and enhance the oversight functions of the KEFOC to ensure accountability, transparency, and effectiveness. This would include creating an Office of Employment First within the Governor’s Office as well as staff to support the work of the Commission.

Without a coordinating entity with true accountability for Employment First implementation, collaborating state agencies lack a unifying message around the importance of employment outcomes and a quality management process or feedback loop. Many respondents discussed the need for increased resources and operating policies to support coordination and messaging. Strengthening leadership around employment as a priority is a first step in the development of more concrete practices that respondents recommended and will be discussed more in detail throughout this report, including the development of a permanent employment lead position with KDADS, enhanced and coordinated benefits planning efforts for job seekers, and increased coordination around transition planning for youth with disabilities.

Beyond the state agencies, there are many stakeholders that have had roles as advocates for increased employment outcomes and have been part of leading the charge for Employment First. The KanCare Advocates Network brings together a group of 50 organizations to advocate for change in legislation. Advocates have been frustrated with the implementation of Employment First and expressed that state agencies have not been held accountable to implement the law. Many respondents have concerns about providers who still hold 14(c) certificates allowing for sheltered workshops that pay subminimum wages. In contrast, some stakeholders have expressed concern that access to a full spectrum of supports and services for people with IDD will be restricted by the implementation of Employment First. Some respondents discussed continuing advocacy to maintain 14(c) employment opportunities and services as a barrier to advancing Employment First, and messaging needs to address this perceived conflict. Respondents noted that the managed care organizations (MCOs) in Kansas could be more influential in this area. One respondent noted: “The culture in Kansas is that the MCOs are really expected to be leaders, and I have found that providers and people who work for the state are very receptive to that.” [...] “[MCOs have] leverage, [they] have influence, but [they] haven’t used it effectively.”

Respondents linked the lack of clear leadership with the absence of a shared set of values. They discussed the need for a change in philosophy, attitudes, and principles that must precede changes in policies, procedures, and systems. “We don’t want necessarily policies and procedures

(without) ... philosophical buy-in. [...] If we can come over and explain the philosophy [...] a lot of this will evolve and take care of itself.”

Leadership Recommendations:

- » Identify a lead entity responsible for convening state partners and guiding the development of goals, implementation plans, and accountability structures for Employment First.
- » Strengthen state agency messaging and oversight about employment outcomes to provide a unified message and support accountability. Support an Employment First web portal that holds stories, guidance, implementation tools, outcome data, and resources.
- » Market and communicate the role of employment in working-age Kansan’s lives and promote that messaging across all platforms and entities.
- » Establish a leadership council of managing agencies. Move Employment First grant coordinating committee into state leadership structure as a state managed entity.

2. Goals and Operating Policies

In successful Employment First systems, state and local agency goals and operating policies require and support CIE and postsecondary education as the first and preferred options in planning and service delivery for youth and working-age adults with IDD. The Kansas Employment First legislation provides a framework for policy but is not specific in how state agencies should fully implement the policy. Many of the state agency representatives and other respondents emphasized the need to review and update state policies and procedures, including service definitions and guidance, to better reflect Employment First as a priority. One respondent said: “The problem is we have this law on the books. But none of those operational changes have been made to actually effectuate the law.” There was a high level of agreement among respondents that state agencies need to do more to operationalize the policies and practices that will result in greater employment opportunities. Another said: “[We need to)] think through how people end up in non-competitive, non-integrated settings and to work backwards from there and to work on detailed, recommended changes to state policy, procedure, policy manuals, procedural manuals, operations, operational manuals, rules and regulations, [and] programmatic changes, that inserts Employment First into person-centered planning.” The theme of operationalization of values through policy and procedure change to promote accountability was clear in both the interview data as well as the policy documents and KEFOC reports. “In order to make this policy an everyday reality, it must require KSDE, School Boards, and local Schools to have and provide procedures, processes, training/technical assistance, and accountability mechanisms to ensure this policy actually occurs” (Report 3 Employment First Transition Recommendations).

Despite a landscape where Employment First values are espoused but bureaucratic and historic policies hamper implementation, Kansas has moved forward with an exception policy within its waiting list for IDD Waiver services. A unique strength of Kansas’s IDD Waiver is the provision that youth who participate in VR and enter a competitive integrated job can bypass the waiver waiting list. This type of innovation offers an example of a concrete policy the state has put into place to promote better employment outcomes for transition-age youth. Kansas has also innovated by investing in developing state tax incentives that support the state’s Employment First goals. It is unclear how widely the tax incentive is used or promoted during the job search, and thus the development of a framework for outreach and information is critical.

Complex Operating Procedures

State agencies set policies to drive the implementation of support at the provider level. However, within a managed care environment, Kansas has multiple levels of policy and operating procedures that affect community providers, including (but not limited to) service definitions, provider qualifications, reporting requirements, and person-centered support planning.

With respect to KDADS, respondents noted that the process to become a provider is complex with little guidance offered by the state. One complicating factor is the multiple layers within the system, which includes the MCOs as well as the Community Developmental Disability Organizations (CDDOs). Further, becoming certified to provide support under one waiver does not enable a provider to provide support under the other six waivers within KDADS. Thus, typically a provider will only be certified to support individuals under one waiver. A respondent described a time-intensive pathway toward provider certification, which includes a Medicaid enrollment period of typically 60–90 days; KDADS licensing, which takes approximately 6–9 months; then a period of credentialing under the MCO; and an affiliation period with the CDDO. This pathway is not easily accessible or well-publicized for providers who are interested in the process.

Provider Qualifications Vary across State Agencies

With the current structure involving overlapping roles in service management for people with IDD across KDADS, KDHE, MCOs, and CDDOs, accountability for promoting employment is not always clear. There are a variety of places where employment should be emphasized. Current contracts state that every MCO must have a certified employment specialist. However, the emphasis on employment can vary among the three MCOs, and one respondent noted that MCO staff receive little training on employment as a priority. CDDOs have an opportunity to highlight employment as a priority service and support selection of providers that achieve quality employment outcomes for individuals they serve.

Service Navigation and Support Coordination

One prominent example of the complexities of navigating operating policies can be found within the state's case management structure. Findings from the respondent interviews suggested a great deal of confusion in the areas of case management, support coordination, and care coordination. The processes for eligibility determination and support coordination are complex, with multiple points of contact that have overlapping roles. This complex structure has an impact on entry into services, messaging about employment as a priority outcome, and accountability for initiating conversations about employment, developing employment goals, and implementing services.

Using the IDD Waiver as an example, for eligibility, individuals apply for services through the CDDO. The CDDO determines functional eligibility. KanCare Clearinghouse determines financial eligibility. Targeted Case Management (a state plan funded service) is made available once IDD eligibility is determined. The KDADS IDD Waiver manager sends an offer letter when services are available with a required 15-day response. For program entry, the CDDO manages provider choice and provides a list of available providers. While CDDOs are assigned the role of maintaining a list of providers in their region and supporting provider choice, other supports, including a targeted case manager (TCM) or care coordinator, may have a closer understanding of an individual's goals and support needs. Next, the IDD Waiver manager sends approval to Kansas Department of Health and Environment (KDHE) and KanCare Clearinghouse. The KanCare Clearinghouse approves eligibility and forwards the approval to the chosen MCO. The MCO assigns a care coordinator. For service planning, the MCO is responsible for developing the individual person-centered plan and selecting agency-directed or self-directed services. The TCM "assists in gaining access to medical, social, educational and other needed services." Finally, with respect to service oversight, the MCO care coordinator is responsible for quarterly meetings.

Goals and Operating Policy Recommendations:

- » Review and update state policies and procedures, including waiver service definitions and guidance, to better reflect Employment First as a priority.
- » Simplify eligibility and the service management process by reducing the number of touch points. For example, centralize functional and financial eligibility into a single point of contact and simplify waiting list management.
- » Establish guidance on the roles and interrelationships of TCM, case managers, MCO care coordinators, and CDDOs. Clarify accountability for Employment First outcomes at the support coordination level. Clearly define a lead entity for person-centered planning and goals. Develop an FAQ or guidance document for families and stakeholders.
- » Acknowledge economic self-sufficiency for individuals as a priority in the policy/procedure.
- » Ensure individual service plans require that an individual's employment status be addressed, and places employment in a clear and visible place within the service plan.

3. Funding

States with high rates of CIE use funding as a strategy to prioritize employment for transition-age youth and working-age adults. In Kansas, key informants shared that one reason for the state's low rates of employment services and outcomes is the low payment rates paid for employment services. This has contributed to low levels of provider capacity, both in terms of the number of providers and adequate staffing for existing providers, and thus investment in employment services in general. One respondent called the system "brittle" and said that: "We've made progress in the last seven years on funding for the system, but we're still far behind where we should have been...[it] kept us from any sort of meaningful innovation."

Even with the recent rate adjustments, supported employment services are funded at a significantly lower rate than facility-based and day services, making it difficult for providers to expand access to services that lead to CIE. Kansas has one of the lowest service payment rates for supported employment in the nation. Key informants shared that they "make more money if we're doing a sheltered workshop" than if they provide supported employment services.

In states that are using funding as a tool to improve integrated employment outcomes, more competitive and integrated work settings receive higher reimbursement rates, while less competitive and less integrated settings receive lower rates. One way of understanding comparability of rates is to view them as a rate per staff work hour.

This is difficult in Kansas because the current rate structures do not define a relationship between level of support need and staff-to-participant ratio. We use Kansas's FY2023 payment rates for day services tiers 1 to 5, day services super tier 1 to 5, and supported employment services to illustrate this issue. Even though the day services rates per 15-minute billing unit per client in the lowest tiers are lower than for supported employment, when the rate is calculated to reflect the staff-to-client ratio, providers are paid more for day services for tier 1 than for supported employment. This discrepancy grows greater when we calculate the rates for day services at higher tiers and for all day services super tier rates.

Table 2. Rates Expressed as Per Direct Support Staff Working Hour*FY2023 rates*

Service	Assumed Ratio (Staff: Client)	Rate/15 Minutes/Client	Rate/Staff Hour Based upon Staff/Client Ratio
Day Services Tier 1 to 5	1:6	\$2.73-7.25	\$65.52-\$174.00
Day Services Super Tier 1 to 5	1:4	\$6.22- \$8.79	\$99.52-\$140.64
Supported employment	1:1	\$10.00	\$40.00

Another concern expressed was that the current supported employment payment rates do not adequately account for non-billable activities that are typically completed as part of the delivery of supported employment services. In general, and depending on the service definition, it is typical for supported employment professionals to bill for between 60% and 75% of their time spent completing supported employment tasks after excluding paid time off, time spent in training and administrative responsibilities, and other nonspecific work tasks. With that adjustment, the per staff working hour rate in Table 2 would adjust to \$24-\$30 per staff working hour. Many respondents also noted that there was ambiguity with respect to what specific activities are and are not billable under the supported employment service.

The current structure of the IDD Waiver funding structure has made the provision of day services seem more stable and consistent. Providers report that they have provided employment supports under other service types or are not engaging in supported employment at all.

During Kansas' participation in the NEON project, a significant emphasis was also placed on outcome-based payment methodologies and recognizing individual differences in level of support need. Reflecting on this, a key informant felt that even an increased rate for supported employment will not fully address this issue. Providers would still lose income because they cannot bill for the time an individual is employed without onsite job coaching, whereas they can bill for the entire time a person spends in a day service. Overall, stakeholders wanted KDADS to clarify how they may compensate providers for the time the individual is actually on the job, rather than for face-to-face service hours. In addition, stakeholders also wanted more transparency regarding the development of support tiers, staff ratios, and payment rate per individual.

Funding Recommendations:

- » Create a funding structure that incentivizes employment by increasing the re-imbursement rate. Have KDADS unbundle day and supported employment services, to allow each activity to have its own reimbursement rate and to distinguish between service investments and participant activities.
- » Clarify the role of tiers and staff ratios in funding. Currently, there is limited guidance about the relationship between funding tiers and staff ratios. This makes it difficult to assess the relationship of rates to costs across services.
- » Develop clear definitions of allowable/billable services under the new employment rate for supported employment and implement rewards and incentives for providers to achieve CIE for people with disabilities.
- » Support providers to understand how to be financially stable as they work to implement Employment First, engage in provider transformation away from sheltered workshops to more integrated community jobs, and ultimately use KDADS HCBS Medicaid Waivers to support people with disabilities in employment.
- » Develop and implement revised IDD Waiver services and service definitions:
 - Strengthen focus on HCBS settings rule and use of community life engagement as a

pathway to employment

- Consider adding a career planning and discovery services
- » Consider including employment in other waivers.
- » Develop a targeted waiver to support employment outcomes with a limited array of services to provide a rapid pathway to services.

4. Interagency Collaboration

Collaboration and Accountability

When Employment First is thriving within a state, there is a shared statewide intra-and inter-agency responsibility and authority for coordinating transition services and achieving CIE for youth and working-age adults with IDD. This collaboration draws on the participation of a broad consortium of stakeholders across the state. Collaborating public agencies should at a minimum include state and local education, VR, workforce, IDD, and Medicaid agencies.

In Kansas, while state agencies involved in disability services convene regularly through various meetings, there has not been an opportunity to establish and track statewide and shared agency level goals for Employment First implementation. As with many states, respondents and documents reviewed described a history of fragmented collaboration around employment for people with disabilities. Many people who receive services have several agencies with whom they engage. These agencies often use differing language and terminology and varying and potentially conflicting processes, structures, and communication mechanisms. Respondents spoke of the need for a common language across state agencies and a central access point for families and individuals. Collaboration around service coordination was mentioned as a particular barrier. The complex infrastructure between MCOs, CDDOs and KDADS, as well as perceptions of ambiguity and overlap between the TCM structures and care coordinators, indicate the need for more effective interagency collaboration.

With respect to streamlined transitions between VR and Waiver services, the process was described as lengthy and complicated, but a recent change in VR leadership was described as a boon to increased collaboration.

Education stakeholders that participated in interviews wanted to further the collaborations that would put students on a post-graduation pathway toward employment. They expressed concern about VR's capacity and commitment to fully embed counselors in individual education planning (IEP) meetings and in pre-ETS planning for transition-age youth. One respondent noted, "when nobody [from VR] shows up [at IEP meetings] for adult services, they do stop getting invited. And that is on DOE. However, that lack of trust is earned on [VR's] part." There was also a concern that in some cases, sheltered workshop providers have been engaged in IEP meetings, and community employment providers are absent.

Transition councils in schools are meeting interagency collaboration gaps. The state has recently secured additional funding for transition councils to increase interagency collaboration. Another area of need key informants reported in interviews was blending and braiding funding across agencies during student transition from school to adult services. This was also found in the document review process.

There was much discussion with respondents about the important role of KDADS in fostering interagency collaboration. The addition of an employment specialist within KDADS has been furthering goals around collaboration, especially with respect to connections within schools. A respondent noted the keen interest from education professionals around Employment First.

Interagency Collaboration Recommendations:

- » Improve service coordination and use of universal language: Many people with disabilities work with a variety of agencies that use different processes, procedures, and terminology.
- » Develop a collaborative flow chart that maps employment services and supports across state agencies and populations to ease service navigation for all partners, including individuals and families.
- » Work with partner systems to establish clear expectations for the future of subminimum wage employment, including the administration of 14c certificates.
- » Provide clarity on implementation of WIOA Section 511 requirements in coordination with VR, education, and workforce systems that reflect intent of individuals to explore CIE before accepting subminimum wage employment.

5. Training and Technical Assistance

In states where Employment First is a priority, the state and its local communities invest significantly in training and technical assistance to help people with disabilities find and grow in their jobs. These investments are targeted at multiple levels, including state agency staff, schools, community providers (like day program and sheltered workshop staff), youth and young adults, their families, and employers.

In Kansas, both respondents and stakeholder reports described the need for training and competency development on employment services and supports across the variety of state agencies people with disabilities and their families work with. Stakeholders with longevity in the field talked about important trainings historically available that focused on the value of employment. Individuals and families talked about issues with turnover and retaining knowledgeable staff who are focused on person-centeredness and strengths-based models.

Discussions focused on the importance of increased training around customized employment as well as the use of the Charting the LifeCourse model. Embracing these types of models with consistency and intention is key to strengthening the knowledge and skills of the Kansas direct support workforce that supports employment. A respondent talked about the importance of cementing strengths-based values within the system, and the challenges that they currently face. “We look first at low expectations, before we look at the gifts and talents of students with disabilities. [...]” Many respondents talked about a culture in Kansas where it can be difficult to challenge the status quo. In that same vein, training must have a foundation in the fundamental value that employment is a key component of adulthood and a path to greater independence and self-sufficiency. This was mentioned as an area of particular importance for educators because youth and families start building their expectations around adulthood and employment early in their school experiences. Kansas’s Families Together sponsors the Family Awareness Employment Training (FEAT), which is a 2-day training for families, youth, and young adults. It includes breakout sessions for youth and helps participants build employment expectations.

Good relationships and collaboration among agencies are the hallmark of an effective statewide training effort. Currently, the Department of Commerce as part of the Kansas Equitable Transition Model (KSETM) initiative is leading a planning process for establishing shared requirements for provider training across funding and service streams and identifying training resources. This interagency effort will also develop and pilot Kansas-based training for employment support professionals that is approved by the Association of Community Rehabilitation Educators (ACRE). The KSETM’s Job Coach Training Working Group has also reviewed strategies used by other states to support implementation of best practices after training, including mentorship and technical support for employment professionals.

Respondents noted that many of the training opportunities made available have been through external, out-of-state entities. While this could be a boon to generate interest and excitement around best and promising practices to promote employment, there was discussion about inconsistencies and lack of state-specific considerations. There has not been a cohesive or consistent investment in training and technical assistance outcomes developed and built upon Kansas-specific needs.

Document review emphasized multiple strategies to address gaps in training. These include:

- » increased training for school staff
- » dedicated state resources for transition coordinator training
- » self-advocacy training for individuals with disabilities so they have knowledge of services and supports available for employment
- » increased training for case managers around the importance of employment
- » certification processes for direct support professionals who provide employment support

Finally, there was also mention of increased engagement with and training for the business community, including increasing awareness about the tax credit to encourage employers to hire people with disabilities.

Training and Technical Assistance Recommendations:

- » Develop a robust infrastructure for capacity building, including training for employment support professionals, and provide implementation supports such as coaching, mentoring, and technical assistance for both employment support professionals and provider organizations that support adoption of best practices.
- » Establish employment support staff credential or training requirements. Establish mandatory training on employment, implementing the employment conversation, and managing employment services for people providing TCM, care coordinators, and others in the service navigation role.
- » Establish Kansas-specific training that is built upon over time. Currently, most training is from third party entities. A lack of commitment to one training model may create inconsistencies across the state.
- » Offer person-centered and strengths-based training models as a consistent training path, which can be part of improving training direct service staff on employment.

6. Data Collection and Performance Measurement

In higher performing states, data on service delivery and employment outcomes for youth and working-age adults with IDD are shared by state agencies and used to track progress and support state agencies and policymakers in developing policies and procedures. In Kansas, respondents and stakeholder reports indicated the need for a more robust data collection system. One stakeholder said: “Data has been a source of frustration all along.” Respondents felt that the move to the MCO structure posed a significant challenge to data tracking, availability of data, and data accuracy.

State-level reports have consistently noted the lack of established data benchmarks or targets to improve upon those measures. KEFOC reports have noted that most state agencies are not sufficiently tracking data about the numbers of Kansans with disabilities in CIE and the number of students entering a sheltered workshop or day supports.

The state legislature has not invested funding in developing a performance measurement system, or a way to track employment data for people with disabilities. Therefore, there is no clear way

of telling who is getting services or who is employed. The previous data system was described as collecting data subjectively without operational definitions. For example, someone looking at earnings data would not be able to tell if earnings were from CIE or participation in sheltered workshops. Another example is with respect to how providers bill for employment services. If providers are providing employment supports but billing under another service code, data would not reflect the individual as “counted” as having employment. There were also reports of large inconsistencies with overall number served from year to year: “One year, they’re reporting that there were 3,000 people in supported employment, and then the year before, there was 115, and then the next year there were 3,900.”

The state requires quarterly outcome reporting from MCOs. However, MCOs do not have reporting guidelines from the state and their reports are not required to track employment data, leaving it up to each MCO to determine how to gather and report data. The state collects data on post-school outcomes (Indicator 14), but respondents noted that it has not been used to evaluate or advocate for improving services or to inform decision making: “There’s really no use, no follow-up. Nobody really looks at it. Nobody really uses it to make decisions to improve anything.”

Previous state administrations have made efforts to improve data collection systems and enhance accountability, one of which was through establishing the Governor’s Subcabinet on Disability where stakeholder agencies convened. An agenda item they worked on was to begin talking about practical ways that state agencies could identify common data elements or common measures of success. But these efforts, including the continuation of the Governor’s Subcabinet on Disability, were not sustained by the current administration. Although the state has plans for a new data system consistent with new funding mechanisms, it has not yet been implemented. It is important to note there are pockets of innovation in developing and using data. Down Syndrome Innovations is very data driven and provides an excellent example of how to use a comprehensive data system.

Data Collection and Performance Measurement Recommendations:

- » Identify data sources and reporting requirements for employment outcomes for each Employment First managing entity. Data may be collected differently but should meet common definitions for outcomes.
- » Include engagement in activities other than CIE in the data on IDD Waiver services for context. This should include facility-based work and day supports.
- » Implement at least annual outcome reporting by agency.
- » Clarify the role of MCOs in data reporting and accountability. MCO contracts should incorporate goals and a mechanism for reporting progress in improving the numbers of Kansans with disabilities in CIE.

7. Services and Service Innovation

Support for service innovation is an important component of an effective and continuously improving system. In successful Employment First states, state agencies create opportunities for schools, providers, youth, and working-age adults with IDD and their families to use best practices and creatively develop supports for transitioning to postsecondary education and CIE.

Respondents consistently spoke about the barriers with respect to how the service system operates and limited opportunities for sustaining innovative practices. An ongoing issue discussed was staff turnover and how it affects the system. A family member expressed frustration with high staff turnover and how important consistency is for relationship-building with staff, including case managers. Staffing shortages are prevalent throughout the system and pose particular challenges in VR and pre-ETS services.

Respondents and stakeholder reports revealed an overall disconnect between the service system and the needs of families and individuals receiving services. A respondent shared that she asked families, “‘well, who’s your care coordinator?’ And they’re like, ‘what’s that, who’s that?’ They don’t even know.” Regarding service navigation, supports are available, and CDDOs are a valuable starting point from which to gather information. The Kansas Commission on Disability Concerns has prepared statewide maps of resources available, and the Transition Transformers group has also developed a resource guide. However, even though these tools exist, knowledge about the system and how to navigate it is perceived as limited. As noted throughout the reviewed reports, individuals and families should have to “learn the lingo” to receive a needed service.

A family member characterized services and supports as having inconsistent messaging around employment. They shared a story about how their loved one was already working part time in an integrated job in high school, and during transition, the education team pushed for a sheltered workshop. The individual completed high school and went on to work full time with natural supports. Document analysis also showed that increasing expectations around employment during transition planning is an area of need. This starts with engaging students in robust roles in IEP meetings and supporting students and families to develop an evolving vision for employment. Project Search was mentioned as an important innovation that leads to community employment outcomes for youth. Another area of need mentioned was greater support for pilot projects that show promise, so that effective practices can be implemented more robustly throughout the state.

The theme of natural supports as an alternative to using the formal system was prevalent throughout discussions. Self-advocates, people with IDD, and families often turn to natural supports to obtain and sustain CIE. They feel that they cannot rely on, or consistently access, paid supports and services because of staffing shortages and service availability. In two separate cases, self-advocates shared that they were directed toward employment in a fast-food restaurant as their only option. Through their own self-advocacy and drive, they went on to do volunteer work as a pathway to other professions that they were interested in. From there, they used their natural on-the-job supports to succeed and move forward in those roles. Respondents noted that because of the large waiting list for waiver services, many individuals rely on family for support.

Benefits Planning

Individuals and families have limited experience with benefits counseling and support. They are not often aware of the policies they can take advantage of for earning money and retaining benefits. This lack of awareness can steer individuals and families away from CIE. The Social Security Administration supports state Work Incentives Planning and Assistance (WIPA) projects, but Kansas is not currently engaged in that initiative. Kansas does have robust benefits planning resources available through KDHE Working Healthy benefits specialists and through the Department of Commerce. Respondents mentioned the FEAT training was available with the goals of increasing expectations for families around employment for young adults with disabilities, and increasing knowledge of state and federal resources to support employment.

Services and Service Innovation Recommendations:

- » Strengthen employment as a focus area in the person-centered service plan. Embed specific requirements related to employment in the person-centered service plan.
- » Establish single state level infrastructure for benefits counseling and support that is available to all populations (as not to establish competing benefits planning pathways). KDHE has a robust infrastructure in place. The state should also expand benefit counseling messaging across populations and consider a tiered structure with a local (e.g. CDDO, community mental health center, center for independent living) entity trained first point of contact, similar to Michigan. Kansas should also consider application to the WIPA program

to expand resources.

- » Develop clear guidance on the role of MCOs in Employment First.
- » Develop the state as a model employer initiative.

8. Attention to the Needs of Underserved Populations

We identified three populations as underserved in Kansas. These include:

1. people with disabilities living in rural areas
2. people of color with disabilities and immigrants whose first language is not English
3. people with disabilities in correctional facilities

People with disabilities living in rural areas: Respondents and stakeholder reports indicated that people with disabilities living in rural areas face challenges accessing employment due to a variety of factors, including lack of transportation, inadequate employment service providers, and fewer businesses to employ people. Respondents noted that these challenges have resulted in some families and students relocating to find employment. Students with more complex needs are most affected.

People of color with disabilities and immigrant populations: Another marginalized group discussed is people of color with disabilities and immigrant populations whose first language is not English. Some respondents reported insufficient efforts to promote equitable access to employment services for these populations. For example, a respondent shared about a lack of Spanish-speaking staff in workforce centers in areas with a large Spanish-speaking population.

Most respondents were not aware of specific efforts to promote equitable access to employment services for people of color, either by state agencies or other providers in the state. A few respondents shared some strategies that their agencies were using to promote equitable access. For example, one respondent reported that their organization was starting to implement a targeted effort to promote equitable access to employment, including hiring a director of health equity, a tribal liaison, and bilingual staff as well as providing translations/interpretation services and training staff on cultural humility and competency. All of these efforts were required under their new contract with the state.

People with disabilities in correctional facilities: Respondents also shared that people with disabilities in correctional facilities or those transitioning from prisons and halfway houses required additional support to consistently access employment services and supports.

Attention to the Needs of Underserved Populations Recommendations:

- » Use geographic data in the state to identify specific areas or districts that may require targeted assistance in transitioning to CIE opportunities.
- » Develop models for the provision of remote/virtual support or mobile services in rural areas.
- » Support transportation services to help IDD Waiver participants, especially those in rural areas, to pay for transportation for work.
- » Invest in the provision of culturally competent supports. For example, Massachusetts Department of Developmental Services funds multicultural family support centers, which hire bilingual staff who provide culturally responsive services and support, including language interpretation.
- » Invest in strengthening services for people in corrections facilities and those who are justice involved, especially in the area of mental health.

9. Self-Advocates and Families

Buy-in and Prioritization

Self-advocates emphasized that when there is a strong commitment to Employment First—and it's treated as a top priority among all available options—it leads to real implementation. A respondent hoped that “we can find a way to finally get it going and maintaining it, [...] just getting people to buy in. [...] It's very important for people to keep it on the front burner and keep working on it to make sure that it just doesn't get pushed aside.”

Self-advocates and others expressed the importance of educating families and professionals on myths and perceptions about people with disabilities in CIE to change values and mindsets and address fears. It is paramount that we change the status quo and and treat people with IDD as individuals with goals. These values are demonstrated when people with disabilities are encouraged to pursue different types of jobs, reflecting a person-centered planning process that honors each person's interests, skills, and goals.

Including, Listening to, and Amplifying the Voices of Self-Advocates is Important

To make positive change and advance Employment First in Kansas, it is crucial to meaningfully include people with IDD in planning and decision-making. Listening to people with IDD, especially at a legislative level and when it comes to their services, would make a positive difference according to self-advocates and advocates. It is important to also improve the teaching of self-advocacy skills.

Although many noted that there is a strong advocacy presence in Kansas, respondents shared that individuals and families have not been voices for change. A piece that is missing is involving people with lived experience in effectively advocating. One respondent emphasized that Kansas needs to listen to individuals better because:

“People with disabilities may have some ideas that others (who) don't have a disability may not have ever thought of. The other piece of that too, is a lot of times when people with disabilities don't know what opportunities are out there, they're not given the chance to explore, and to get the help that they need to help find jobs they really want to do.”

Self-Advocates and Families Recommendations:

- » Educate family members and professionals to address myths and fears, particularly around benefits planning.
- » Identify leadership opportunities within the state infrastructure for people with lived experience with disability.
- » Develop plain language resources that help people with disabilities understand important issues and policy changes that affect them.

SECTION 4: NEXT STEPS

To identify priority recommendations, members of the Kansas Employment First Steering Committee were invited to volunteer or were nominated to join a Working Group to help identify the most impactful recommendations for implementation through a series of working group meetings. These meetings were designed to identify and prioritize actionable recommendations that can improve employment outcomes for people with disabilities in Kansas. The Working Group included 11 members representing a wide variety of key stakeholders, including state agencies, provider organizations, disability rights advocates, and self-advocacy organizations. The group met online three times between April and May 2025. The Working Group prioritized the following three recommendations:

1. **Leadership:** Establish an operational leadership group to complement the Governor's Subcabinet on Disability.
2. **Operational Policy:** Build employment as a focus in service planning and mapping processes across various systems.
3. **Funding:** Develop and implement a funding strategy for CIE that reflects evidence-based and best practices in employment, managed care, and interagency collaboration.

The next step involves developing actionable objectives for each of the identified priority areas. To support this process, we will collaborate with KDADS and the Governor's Subcabinet on Disability to establish an operational leadership group that complements the role of the Governor's Subcabinet on Disability. We will also form an interagency working group that brings together all entities involved in case management, ensuring coordinated and inclusive input.

Each working group will develop a concrete action plan to guide implementation. In addition, we will align funding recommendations with the work currently underway in partnership with Public Consulting Group (PCG), ensuring consistency and strategic investment across initiatives.

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About the Institute for Community Inclusion

The Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) is based at the University of Massachusetts Boston. Through training, technical assistance, research, and direct service activities, ICI supports the rights of people with disabilities to participate in all aspects of society. ICI's work encompasses research, program evaluation, training, consultation, education, policy analysis, and service delivery across four main areas of emphasis: Employment, Education, Community Life, and Health Care.



ThinkWork!
INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

ThinkWork! is the Institute for Community Inclusion's (ICI) resource hub offering data, personal stories, innovative practices, and tools related to improving employment outcomes for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). ThinkWork is a collaborator on the Kansas Employment First initiative.

www.ThinkWork.org

LIST OF APPENDICES

Appendix A: External Investments

Appendix B: Prioritized Recommendations

Appendix C: Protocol to Guide Key Informant Interviews

Appendix D: Data Snapshot

APPENDIX A: EXTERNAL INVESTMENTS

Review of Kansas Projects Related to Employment and Community Living for People with Disabilities

Background

The Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) at the University of Massachusetts Boston conducted this review in September 2024, as part of the work led by Kansas University Center on Developmental Disabilities (KUCDD) and the Institute for Health and Disability Policy Studies (IHDPs) at the University of Kansas, funded by Kansas Department of Aging and Disabilities Services (KDADS). The goal of this effort is to develop policy recommendations and create infrastructure to support the full implementation of Kansas Employment First law and ensure CIE as the first and preferred option for Kansans with disabilities.

Findings

This review includes active and recently completed projects as of September 2024. Information includes the project name, agencies involved (current projects only), the stated goal of the project, and dates the project is or was active. One element that ICI staff observed is that while many of the projects listed provide valuable knowledge to help improve the employment system in Kansas, there is no publicly available information on how the lead agency and other state agencies will incorporate project outcomes into employment systems change activities. Additionally, during interviews conducted for this project, interviewees expressed awareness of the different projects, but there was not a comprehensive understanding of how these activities should be applied to Employment First.

Recommendations

There is an open cell in both the current and past projects tables that invites all organizations involved to describe the intended impact that the project will have on Kansas Employment First. Some questions to consider:

- » What opportunities does the lead agency have to use the project outcomes to improve employment?
- » What opportunities do the other agencies involved have to use the project outcomes to improve employment?
- » How is information shared about the project activities and outcomes across all potential partners?
- » Based upon the project activities and outcomes, what recommendations have been made (or are anticipated) to state agencies regarding employment policy and practice?
- » What are the priorities for future investments?

Conclusion

The review of existing projects suggests that Kansas has a wealth of information to incorporate into its Employment First efforts. However, research has consistently shown that for change to be successful, all partners have a role in the problems and challenges that exist, and in creating solutions (Hall et al., 2007; Winsor et al., 2023). There is no single agency or project on its own that can lead to sustainable change. If Kansas is to be successful, partners must review their existing and recently completed projects and intentionally and publicly link the outcomes to progress toward Employment First.

Current Systems Change Projects

Name of Project	Organizations Involved	Goal of Project	Impact	Project Dates
My Transition/ My Career	KUCDD	My Transition/My Career (MTMC) projects are focused on supporting communities to enhance collaborations across existing local systems to improve the experiences and outcomes of youth with intellectual and developmental disabilities as they transition between school and working in the community. Eight Kansas communities are supported.		2021–2026
Kansas Youth Transition Network: Strengthening Partnerships to Advance Transition and Employment Outcomes for Youth	Kansas Department of Education, Kansas Rehabilitation Services, Centers for Independent Living across the state of Kansas, local education providers, the Kansas University Center on Developmental Disabilities, Families Together, and other partners	Kansas Youth Transition Network is a statewide initiative that will help students with disabilities make the transition from education to employment. This grant will help youth with disabilities statewide connect to the supports that meet their individual needs as they transition from high school to college, other postsecondary opportunities, or directly into CIE.		2023–2028
ETM: Equitable Transition Model Demonstration Grant: Kansas Works Youth Initiative	KS Department of Commerce	ETM's goal is to increase access to and use of transition services by disadvantaged youth and young adults with disabilities, resulting in obtaining CIE, reduction in reliance on social security benefits, and increasing independent living.		2023–2028
Evaluation of the Kansas Medicaid STEPS Program	KU IHDP; KDHE; STEPS/Working Healthy	The goal is to evaluate the Medicaid STEPS program for the Kansas Department of Health and Environment (KDHE)		Ongoing
ABLE Opportunity Grant Signup	KCDD/Kansas State Treasurer's Office; Sunflower/ Arcare/CareSource /Kansas Financial Empowerment Foundation	Individuals currently waiting on the Kansas IDD waitlist can access a \$100 ABLE opportunity grant, thanks to financial support from CareSource, Sunflower Health Plan, Arcare, the Kansas Financial Empowerment Foundation, and the Kansas Council on Developmental Disabilities (KCDD)		April 15–October 3, 2024
Kansas Employment First Oversight Commission	Kansas Commission on Disability Concerns	The focus of the commission shall be on increasing the number of Kansans with disabilities in competitive integrated employment.		Ongoing

Name of Project	Organizations Involved	Goal of Project	Impact	Project Dates
SB 387	KSDE	This includes \$75.5 million in additional funding for special education state aid for the upcoming school year. With this increased funding, districts will be better positioned to recruit and retain special education staff and ensure adequate services are provided to students with Individualized Educational Plans (IEPs). This funding represents the first year of a phased-in approach to fully funding special education in accordance with the state's statutory obligation.		SFY2025 (July 2024–June 2025)
Supported Employment Rate Increase	KDADS	This includes \$18.814M of funds to increase Supported Employment Reimbursement Rate to \$40/hour		SFY2025 (July 2024–June 2025)
SB15 14c Provider Transition Funds	DOL, KDADS	This expands an income tax credit for goods and services purchased from qualified businesses that employ disabled workers and that pay those workers at least the minimum wage. This is a Sheltered Workshop Transition Grant Program, a matching grant program that transitions employers away from a federal policy that allows them to pay Kansans with disabilities less than minimum wage. Businesses that pay Kansans with disabilities less than minimum wage are not eligible for the Disability Employment Act tax credit.		10 years starting in SFY2025
SB 333 (Kathy's Bill)	All state agencies	Kathy's Bill creates a Disability hiring preference for state agencies.		Adopted 2024 Legislative Session
Workforce Training and Career Ladder	KDADS, KU, CRADO	This establishes the creation of a Direct Service Worker Workforce Training Program. The program allows training providers to apply for funding to create training and professional development for direct service workers. These competency-based trainings will ensure that direct service workers have the knowledge, skills, and abilities to provide person-centered, quality support. KDADS is working to re-draft RFP language for the Study & Design Career Ladder initiative with stakeholder input, and allocation is \$5,000,000.		Timeline TBD

Name of Project	Organizations Involved	Goal of Project	Impact	Project Dates
IDD and PD Waitlist Study	KUCDD and the Institute for Health and Disability Policy Studies, KDADS	This is a study of both waitlists to determine best way to eliminate such a large waiting list. Partnering agencies would collect and analyze data on the waiting list to determine how to address the needs of people on the state's waiting list for services effectively and efficiently. The budget was \$1,000,000.		2022-2024
IDD TCM Study	KDADS, PCG (Public Consulting Group)	The goal of this study was to eliminate conflict of interests due to Final Rule, provide improved training in areas of employment, benefits navigation, education, strengths model, Charting the LifeCourse, and person-centered planning.		2023-2024
Expansion of Employment First Network of Providers		As initiatives are implemented to phase out 14(c) Subminimum wage statewide for IDD service recipients, Kansas will need to assist current providers in building successful business models around moving away from non-competitive and non-integrated settings to CIE. Additionally, Kansas would like to see the CIE network grow so that Kansans have more options. Allocated Funds: \$1,500,000		Timeline TBD
Remodeling Grants	KDADS	This HCBS providers proposal would include capital investments as permitted under Section 9817 of the American Rescue Plan Kansas proposes to provide grant opportunities to HCBS providers that demonstrate the ability to come into compliance with the HCBS settings criteria, but who have the need of small to moderate capital improvement projects, Allocated Funds: \$5,000,000		Timeline TBD
Person-Centered Support Planning	KDADS; UMKC/ LifeCourse Nexus	The goal of this project is to implement cultural change across Kansas and all waivers to use Charting the LifeCourse as best practice for person- centered planning. Allocated Funds: \$1,000,000		Timeline TBD
Technology 1st	KDADS	The goal of this project is to put technology in the hands of members to support increased independence, socialization, and social determinants of health. Allocated Funds: \$2,000,000		Timeline TBD
SMART Home Technology	KDADS	This project provides grants to providers to implement SMART Home Technology for members to support increased independence, socialization, and social determinants of health. Allocated Funds: \$3,000,000		Timeline TBD

Name of Project	Organizations Involved	Goal of Project	Impact	Project Dates
IDD Tier Rate Assessment	KDADS	This project requests funds to fulfill the biennial requirement of IDD Tier Rate Reimbursement assessments as required by CMS. Allocated Funds: \$1,500,000		Timeline TBD
Self-Advocate Peer Support Training	Healthy Blue/BCBS	The goal of this training is to train self-advocates to be peer supporters.		2024
UniteUs	DCF	The \$7,700,000 in funding will provide software and implementation services for three years to provide DCF users and users from other Kansas agencies, county governments, and health care providers with closed-loop referrals to community-based organizations to help address a client's social care needs. Closed loop is defined as the ability for authorized users to: - receive notification of incoming social care requests or referrals - securely access relevant social care information regarding the social needs and care journey of individuals they serve, with their documented consent and consistent with applicable law - communicate with referring organizations - send social care referrals on behalf of the individual, track and store the outcome of that referral, and track and store the outcome of services delivered within a single client record		2023–current

Previous Systems Change Projects

Name of Project	Goal of Project	Impact	Project Dates
National Expansion of Employment Opportunities Network Initiative (NEON)	This technical assistance initiative advanced collaboration with national provider organizations to develop strategic plans for increasing CIE opportunities for the individuals they serve, including those with significant disabilities and those who have faced barriers to employment.		2023
Kansas Roadmap to Employment	The Council provided the funding to study employment barriers in Kansas for people with disabilities. KCDD partnered with nationally recognized experts in disability employment, Griffin-Hammis and Associates, to analyze these barriers and provide recommendations that would lead to better employment outcomes. Once the study was completed, KCDD worked with state agencies and providers to implement the changes needed to remove these barriers.		2015
Employment Systems Change Coalition	The Employment Systems Change Coalition (ESCC) represented multiple organizations and advocacy groups throughout Kansas who work together across fields of disability to support the common goal of improving employment outcomes for Kansans with disabilities. Members committed to the long-term process of working together to support not only seeing more people employed but also addressing systematic barriers to employment for persons with disabilities.		2018
2022 Special Committee on Intellectual and Developmental Disability Waiver Modernization/ 2023 Special Committee on Intellectual and Developmental Disability Waiver	This is a recommendation to create a Community Supports Waiver: KDADS Secretary Laura Howard announced a partnership with Public Consulting Group (PCG) to assist in the state's plan to modernize the Intellectual and Developmental Disability (IDD) Home and Community-Based Services (HCBS) Waiver by addressing waitlist and workforce challenges, and supporting the state in the development of a new Community Support Waiver (CSW). The PCG partnership included strategic grant funding to support the transformation and improvement of services. Funding initiatives focused on specific service areas like aiding sheltered workshop providers with compliance with new regulations, restructuring CDDOs to eliminate conflicts of interest, and ensuring the impartiality of case management.		September-November 2022
Collaborative on Health Reform and Independent Living (CHRIL)	Kansas University Institute for Health and Disability Policy Studies (IHDPs) completed & current projects		2013–2020
Evaluating the Reliability, Validity, and Sensitivity of Person-Centered HCBS Outcome Measures	IHDPs completed & current projects		2008–2012
Kansas Demonstration to Maintain Independence and Employment (DMIE)	IHDPs completed & current projects		2015–2021

Name of Project	Goal of Project	Impact	Project Dates
Kansas Medicaid: Evaluating Program Satisfaction, Access to Care, and Unmet Needs of Adults with Serious Mental Illness (SMI)	IHDPS completed & current projects		2021-2023
Kansas Medicaid Health Homes	IHDPS completed & current projects		2004-2011
State of Missouri Partnership for Hope HCBS Waiver Evaluation	IHDPS completed & current projects		2016-2017
Reforming Social Security's Disability Benefits System	IHDPS completed & current projects		2012-2014
The Nexus of Employment, Health, and Disability	IHDPS completed & current projects		2012-2014
WORK Allocation and Assessment Project	IHDPS completed & current projects		2012-2013
Working Healthy: The Kansas Medicaid Buy-In Evaluation	IHDPS completed & current projects		2010-2014

APPENDIX B: RECOMMENDATION PRIORITIZATION WORKING GROUP FOR EMPLOYMENT FIRST IMPLEMENTATION

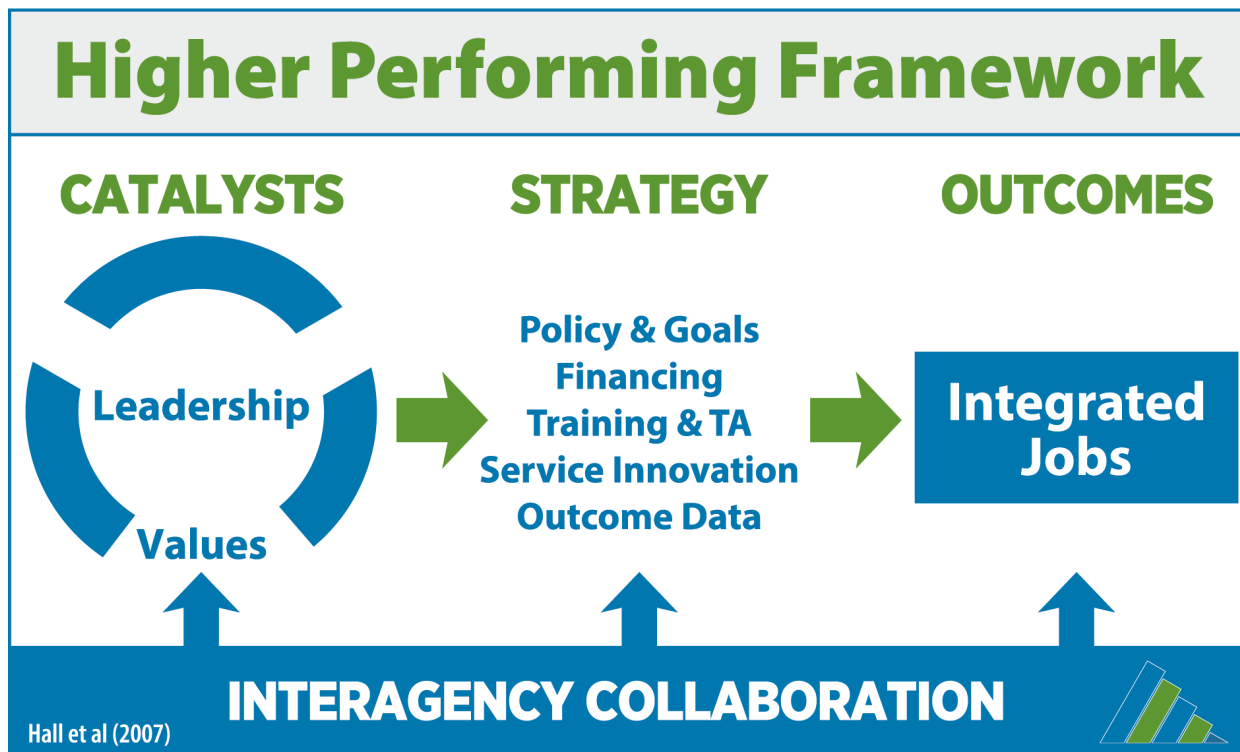
Summary Report

To support the implementation of the Kansas Employment First law, the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston (ICI) organized and facilitated a series of working meetings in the spring of 2025. The ICI leads policy analysis for the Kansas Employment First project.

The purpose of these meetings was to identify and prioritize action steps for state agencies to take to improve employment outcomes for people with disabilities. Members of the Kansas Employment First Steering Committee volunteered or were nominated to join the group and identify their highest system change priorities.

ICI uses the Higher Performing States Framework (see Figure 1) to guide systems change to expand integrated employment in its work across the United States. This type of holistic approach can help Kansas realize a vision of Employment First and increase employment for individuals with intellectual and/or developmental disabilities (I/DD).

Figure 1: Higher Performing States Framework for Integrated Employment



The working group met online three times between April and May 2025. It included 11 members representing a wide variety of key stakeholders, including state agencies, provider organizations, disability rights advocates, and self-advocacy organizations. To prepare for the meetings, members reviewed a draft report developed by ICI about the long-time barriers to Employment First in Kansas. They also reviewed a list of recommendations to address these barriers. Prior to each meeting, working group members ranked their priority recommendations. During the meetings, members discussed the recommendations both as a whole group and in smaller breakout rooms. They worked toward building consensus on the most critical recommendations from the report. The discussions considered ongoing policy implementation efforts, the necessary sequence of actions, and feasibility of the recommendations.

The working group prioritized a series of recommendations presented within relevant elements of the Higher Performing Framework. ICI staff advise structuring the implementation of the recommendations in the following order:

STEP 1:

Leadership: Establish a collaborative operational leadership team to support implementation and monitoring of Kansas' employment goals at the regional and local levels, September 2025

Action Steps:

- » The Disability Employment Subcabinet Group (DESG) and the Kansas Department of Aging and Disability Services (KDADS) should establish the collaborative operational Employment Leadership Team for the purpose of supporting the implementation and monitoring of Kansas' employment goals at the programmatic, regional, and local levels. DESG and KDADS should at a minimum consider the following state agencies for membership: KDADS, Department of Education, Vocational Rehabilitation, Department of Commerce, and Kansas Department of Health and Environment (KDHE).
- » DESG and KDADS should identify dedicated and consistent staff within their state agencies and as appropriate within agency departments and divisions who will comprise the Employment Leadership Team. These staff will support the coordination and implementation of state and agency level strategic employment objectives.

The Employment Leadership Team should propose strategic goals at the state and operating agency level for the next five years. These goals should be shared with the DESG and KDADS for approval and to ensure that efforts align across and within state agencies to promote consistent and coordinated progress.

DESG, KDADS, and the Employment Leadership Team should collaboratively establish methods of coordination between the three entities, as well as administrative processes for the Employment Leadership Team, including, but not limited to: who will convene the team, how information will be shared between the state level groups and team members, and frequency of communication.

STEP 2 (A-C):

Develop and implement a series a of short-term, ad hoc groups that report to the Employment Leadership Team and will address issues related to a) service planning and coordination, b) funding for employment and other services that support employment, and c) capacity building.

2.a. Ad Hoc Group on Service Planning, October–December 2025

Action Steps:

- » The Employment Leadership Team members should identify within their state agencies where the functions of case management and employment planning activities occur for people with disabilities. Members should then appoint staff from their respective agencies to form a 3-month interagency working group. The Employment Leadership Team will include members from Self-Advocate Coalition of Kansas (SACK) and a parent group such as Families Together. The working group will report twice per month to the Employment Leadership Team.
- » The Employment Leadership Team will charge the ad hoc group to identify needed revisions to existing service planning documents and processes so that employment is the priority outcome, with a focus on employment service planning across the lifespan.
- » The ad hoc group should also draft service planning processes that encompass multiple state, regional, and local entities so that individuals are able to access all the potential services that could support their employment outcome.

- » Examples of areas already identified for the ad hoc group to address include:
 - Strengthen the focus on employment during service and person-centered planning conversations, particularly at younger ages, and at all key transition points, including within schools, during adult service planning, and through Pre-Employment Transition Services (Pre-ETS).
 - Develop a standardized pathway tool for coordination and planning, and to help individuals and families navigate services and employment opportunities.
 - Embed and document employment conversations as part of the person-centered service plan.
 - Develop a process to ensure that benefits planning and counseling are part of the service planning process to improve informed choice, access, and coordination of employment and other life supports.
 - Review and make recommendations related to training about employment for personnel who manage person-centered service planning, including those contracted through Community Developmental Disability Organizations (CDDOs) and Managed Care Organizations (MCOs).
 - Adjust intake processes and policies to ensure accountability for employment services and outcomes.
- » Clarify the role of CDDOs and MCOs in presenting service options that emphasize employment. Provide guidance for ensuring these conversations are thorough and consistently implemented.
- » Establish guidance and protocols for quality assurance assessors.

2.b. Ad Hoc Group on Funding for Employment, October–December 2025

Action Steps:

- » The Employment Leadership Team members should identify within their state agencies where service definitions, rate setting, and funding structure implementation occur for people with disabilities. Members should then appoint staff from their respective agencies to form a 3-month interagency working group. The Employment Leadership Team should also consider including members from Interhab, community rehabilitation providers, Disability Rights Center of Kansas (DRC), University of Kansas (KU), SACK, and family groups. The working group will report twice per month to the Employment Leadership Team.
- » The Employment Leadership Team will charge the ad hoc group to identify and develop materials to support the implementation of new funding structures for employment and related services so that employment is the priority at the individual and provider levels.
- » Examples of areas already identified for the ad hoc group to address include:
- » Align funding recommendations with the work currently underway in partnership with Public Consulting Group (PCG) to ensure consistency. Include clarifying billable activities, particularly direct vs indirect services and supports that support providers in delivering services effectively.
- » Identify whether existing funding structures within each agency support funding to access technology that supports employment, including funding for tools and devices that support people in obtaining and maintaining competitive integrated employment. If yes, identify processes to ensure these are widely available and included in the work for the Ad Hoc Group on Person Centered Planning. If no, identify ways other states meet this need.
- » Support providers to implement sustainable business models for employment services.
 - Develop a financial modeling system to support providers in assessing the implementation of proposed rates.

- Develop technical support and resources around funding mechanisms for providers.
- » Identify data that is still needed to support long-term refinement of appropriate reimbursement rates based upon varying levels of support, especially for ongoing employment supports to ensure provider sustainability.

2.c. Ad Hoc Group on Capacity Building, January–March 2026

Action Steps:

- » The Employment Leadership Team members should identify within their state agencies where the functions of training and technical assistance to individuals, families, providers, state agency staff, educators, CDDOs, and MCOs occur related to supporting employment for people with disabilities. Employment Leadership Team members should then appoint staff from their respective agencies to form a 3-month interagency working group. The Employment Leadership Team should also consider including members from Interhab, community rehabilitation providers, DRC, KU, SACK, and Parent Training Organizations (PTOs). The working group will report to the Employment Leadership Team.
- » The Employment Leadership Team will charge the ad hoc group to identify existing opportunities to embed training and technical assistance on employment for these groups. The team could also consider whether an annual statewide Employment First Conference is appropriate.
- » Examples of areas already identified for the ad hoc group to address include:
 - Increase engagement and technical assistance with providers to ensure effective implementation and collaboration throughout the system.
 - Increase the number of certified benefits planners as well as access to basic online benefits information, including contracting with DB101 to create a module for Kansas that can be used by individuals, families, case managers, providers, educators, and others.

The ad hoc groups will seek feedback from key stakeholders on all recommendations as they are developed.

Spring 2025 Working Group Members

Name	Title	Organization
Amanda Ramsey	Special Projects Manager, CPWIC	Kansas Commerce
Colin Olenick	Self-Advocate	Self-Advocate Coalition of Kansas (SACK)
Liz Long	Director, Working Healthy (Work and STEPs programs)	KDHE
Mark Dietzler	Workforce Employment First Specialist	KDADS
Martha Gabehart	Executive Director	Kansas Commission on Disability Concerns (KCDC)
Mike Burgess	Director of Policy and Outreach	Disability Rights Center
Mitzie Tyree	Director of HCBS Initiatives	KDADS
Phil Bentzinger	Director, CESP	Job Link
Rocky Nichols	Executive Director	Disability Rights Center
Seth Kilber	Assistant Commissioner	KDADS
Shelia Nelson-Stout	Chief Executive Officer	OCCK

APPENDIX C: KEY INFORMANT INTERVIEW GUIDE

Kansas is working to turn the promise of Employment First into a reality for Kansans with disabilities. These efforts include the Kansas Employment First Grant. As part of the grant project, the Kansas University Center on Developmental Disabilities (KUCDD) and the Kansas University Institute for Health and Disability Policy Studies (KU IHDPs) have partnered with national experts on disability employment outcomes from the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston (ICI) to develop actionable policy recommendations that lead to enhanced competitive integrated employment outcomes for Kansans with disabilities.

- » What is your experience supporting Employment First in Kansas?
- » How did previous Employment First efforts in Kansas shape where you are today? What was the impetus? What were the facilitators? What strategies have been successful? What were the challenges/barriers? What systems emerged as key partners? What are the lessons learned in the last 10 years that shaped the direction the state is taking?
- » How do Kansas's funding structures for employment and day systems impact employment services and outcomes for people with IDD?
- » How has Kansas used data systems to move forward their initiatives and drive decision making within the state IDD agency?
- » What role have key stakeholders played (family groups, self-advocacy groups, service providers, DD Council, others) and what strategies has Kansas used to connect and integrate these groups?
- » How has the state worked to improve the capacity of employment service providers? How has the state leveraged technical assistance efforts to improve the quality of community employment services and what is the level of cross-pollination among systems?
- » What have been the effects of changes in leadership/continuity, messaging, and communication from leadership within the state IDD agency? VR? Education?
- » How is Kansas responding to the current federal context and climate (e.g., emphasis on elimination of subminimum wage, HCBS Waiver integrated settings rule)?
- » Can you talk broadly about the level of collaboration across the three entities (KSDE, KDADS, DCF/VR)? Is collaboration formal or informal? -Please provide examples.
- » Are there some pockets of innovation in employment service delivery that have emerged?
- » Can you talk about efforts to promote equitable employment outcomes? How does the state promote Employment First for historically marginalized or underserved groups, including people of color with disabilities, Indigenous populations, immigrants, and rural populations?
- » What do you see as solutions/what are your recommendations for promoting employment for people with disabilities in Kansas?
- » What are some lessons learned for other states?
- » What other key factors have we missed?
- » Do you know anyone else we might want to talk to?

Thank you for your participation. If you have any questions, please contact our PI, Allison Hall, Allison.hall@umb.edu

APPENDIX D: KANSAS DATA SNAPSHOT

Data sources

ICI National Survey of State IDD Agency Employment and Day Services

Individuals who participate in an employment or day service funded or monitored by the state IDD agency

National Core Indicators – IDD

A national effort to measure and improve the performance of public developmental disability agencies. The NCI-IDD In-Person Surveys are conversations with adults receiving case management and at least one paid service from the state IDD agency

National Core Indicators – Aging and Disabilities

NCI-AD™ supports states' interest in assessing the performance of programs and delivery systems to improve services for older adults and individuals with physical disabilities

Rehabilitation Services Administration – 911

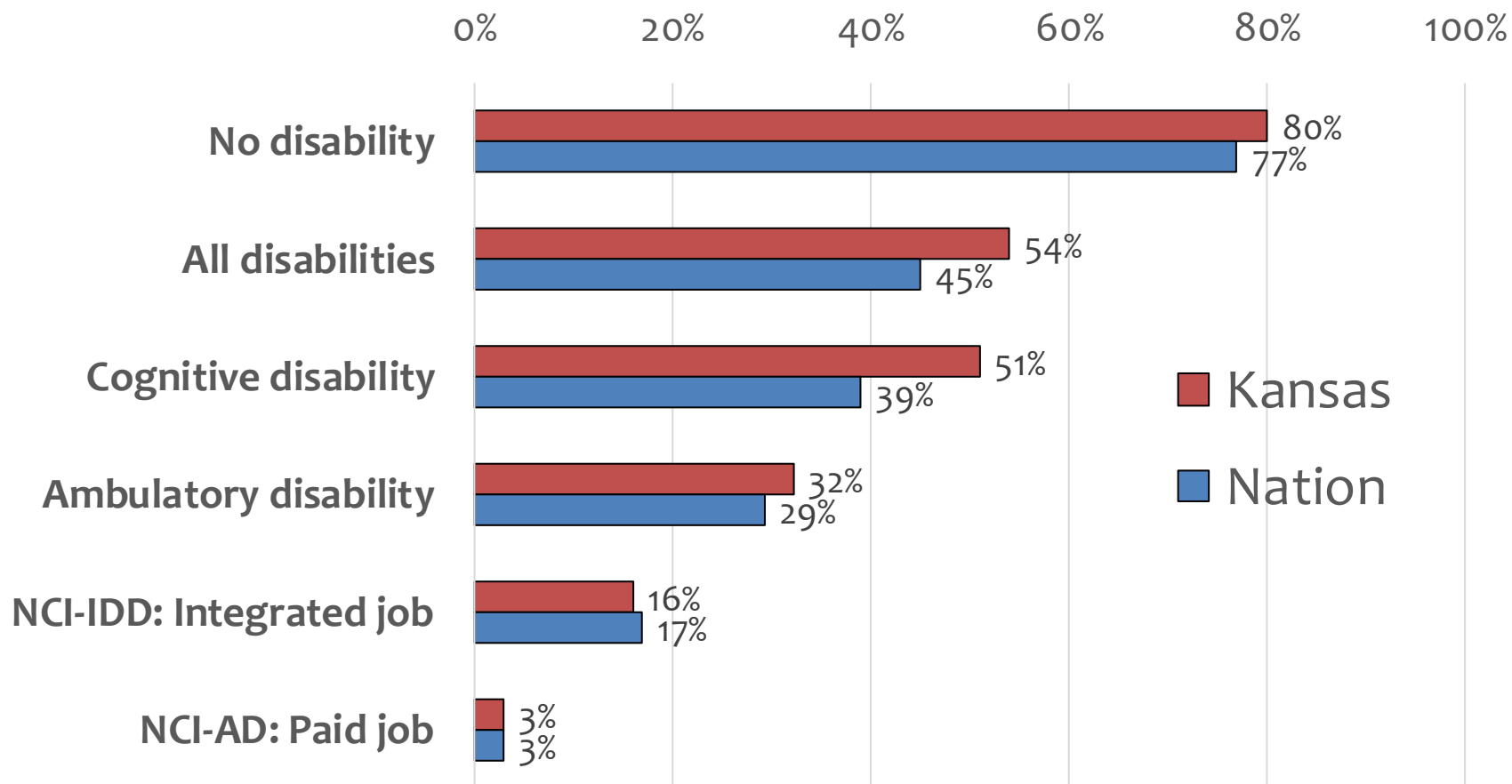
Federal dataset that captures characteristics, services provided, and employment outcomes of individuals receiving vocational rehabilitation (VR) and supported employment services

American Community Survey

Nationwide survey conducted by the US Census. Individuals self report disability status using six broad categories. This summary includes:

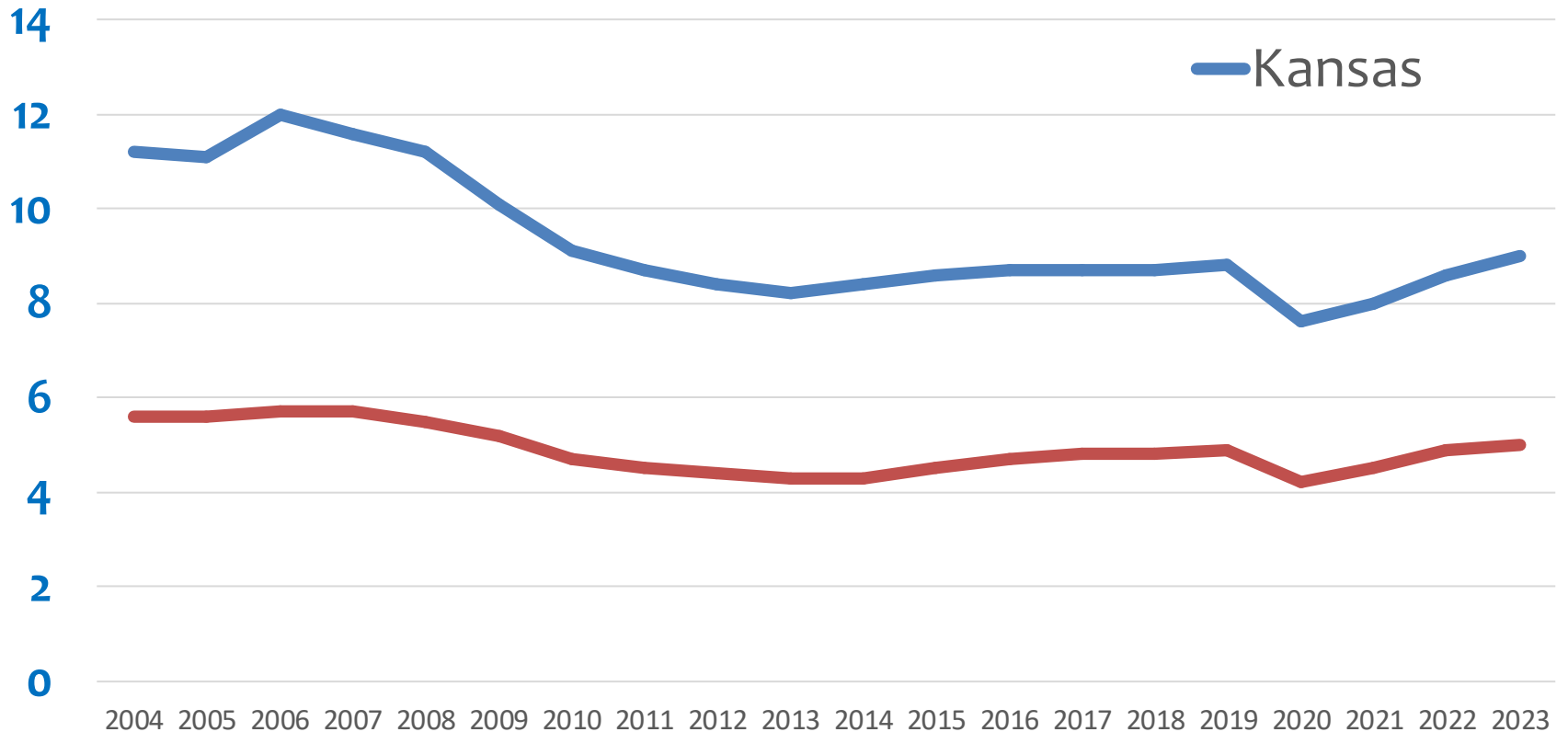
- **No disability.** No reported disability
- **Cognitive disability.** Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does this person have serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?
- **Ambulatory disability.** Does this person have serious difficulty walking or climbing stairs?

Employment participation



Source: ACS 2023, National Core Indicators 2022-23

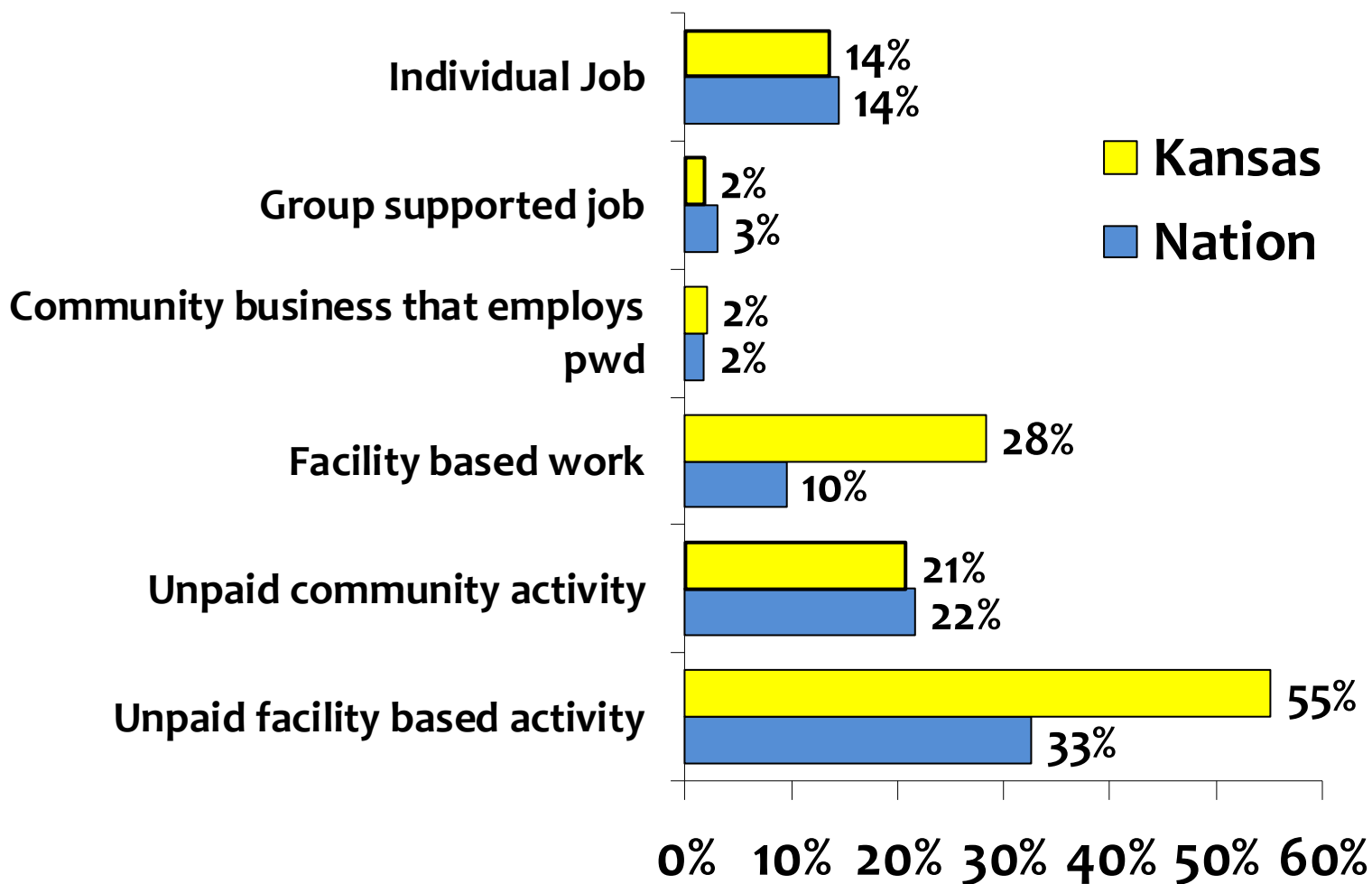
Percent SSI recipients who work



Source: SSA

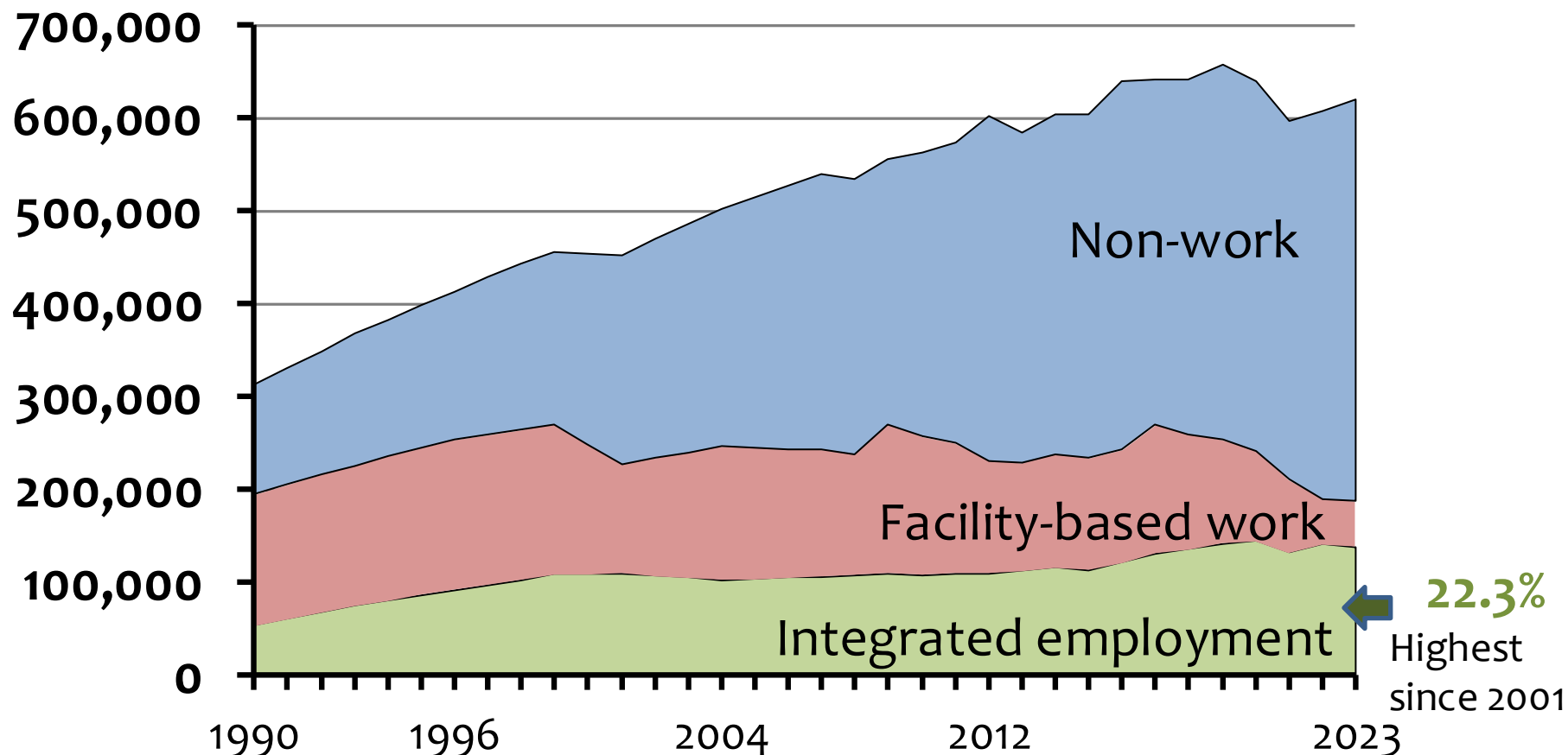
Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities

How people spend their day 2022-2023



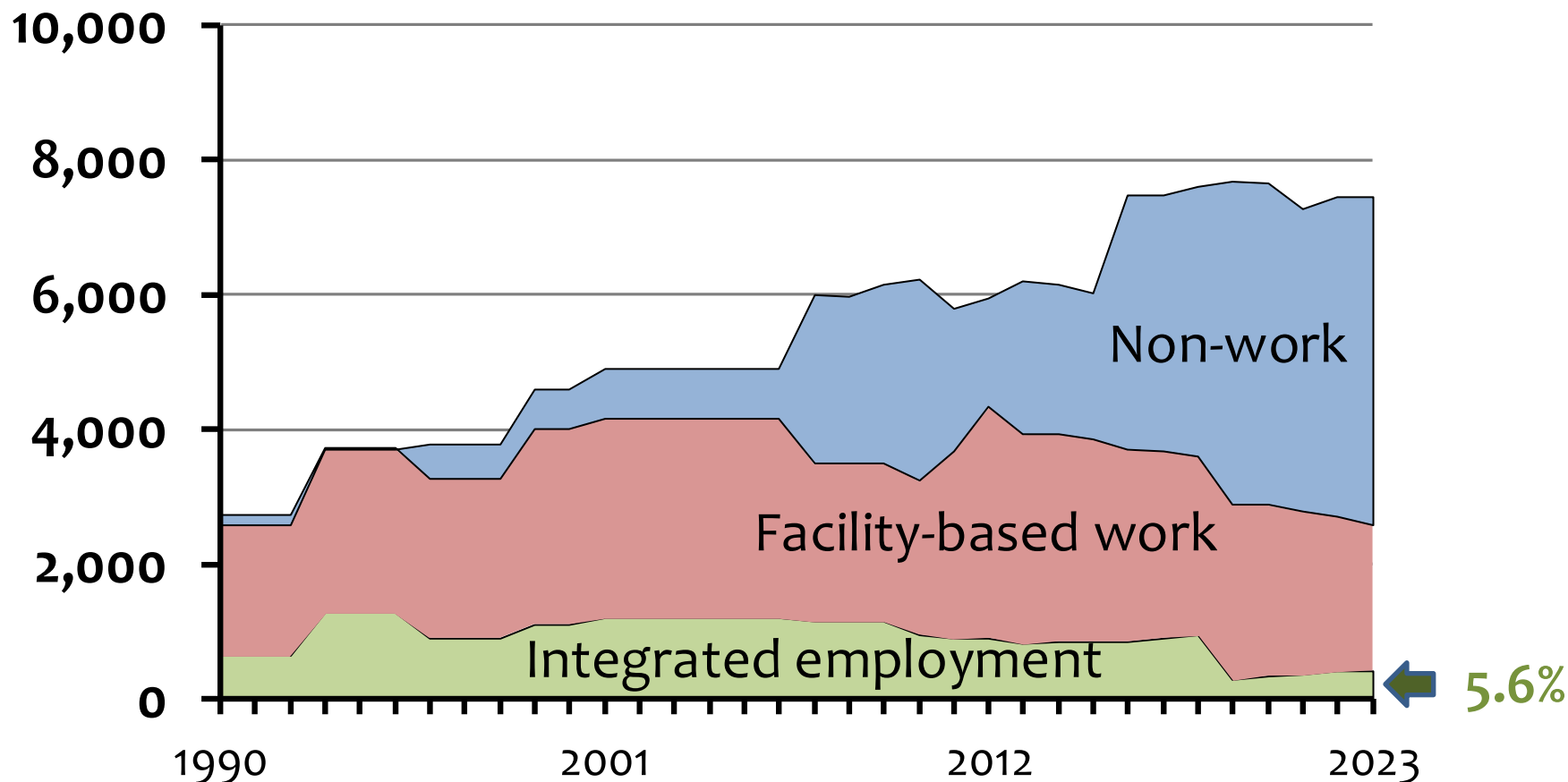
Source: National Core Indicators - IDD

Number in Employment and Day Services - National



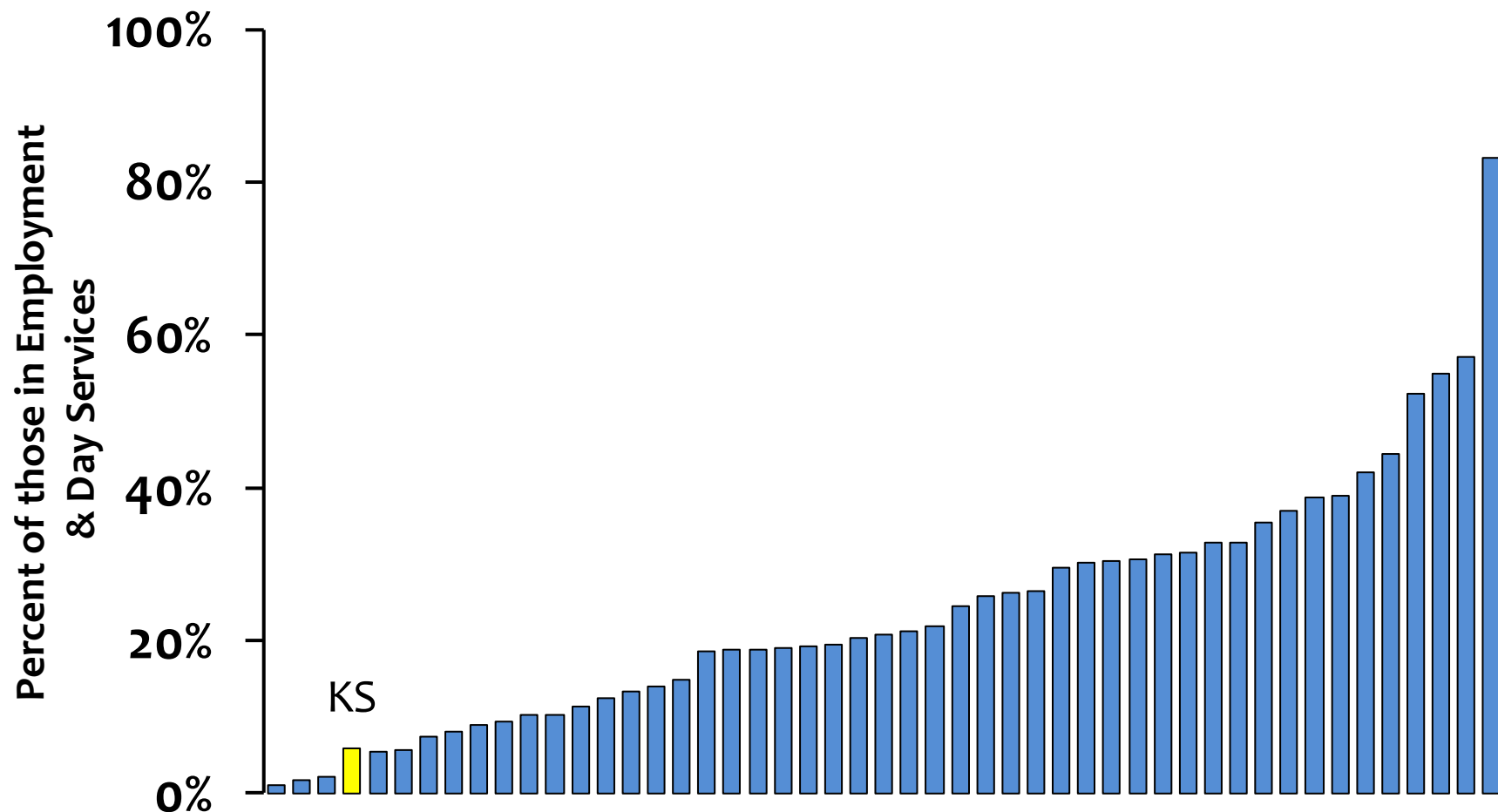
Source: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agencies

Number in Employment and Day Services - Kansas



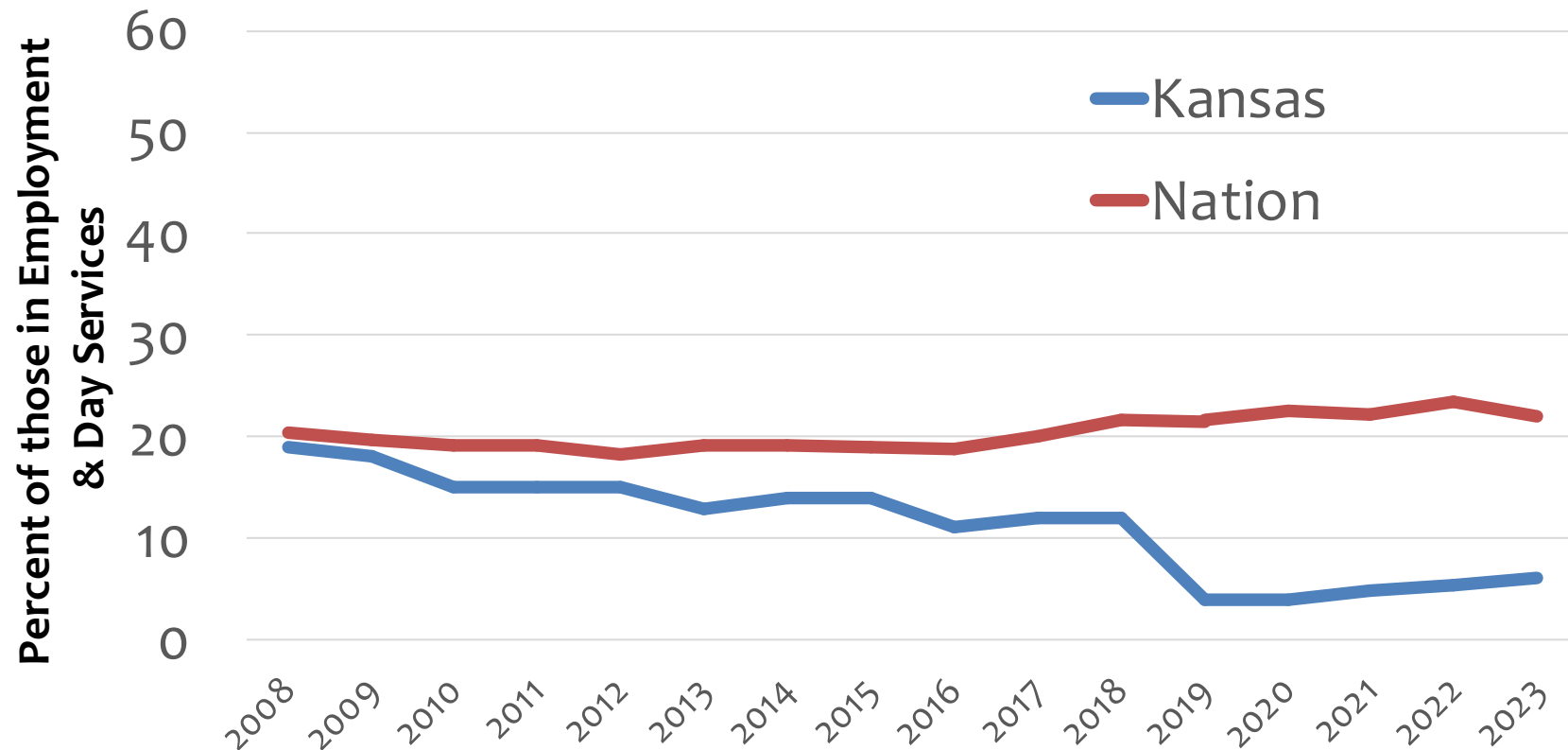
Source: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agencies

Participation in integrated employment services



Source: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agencies FY2023

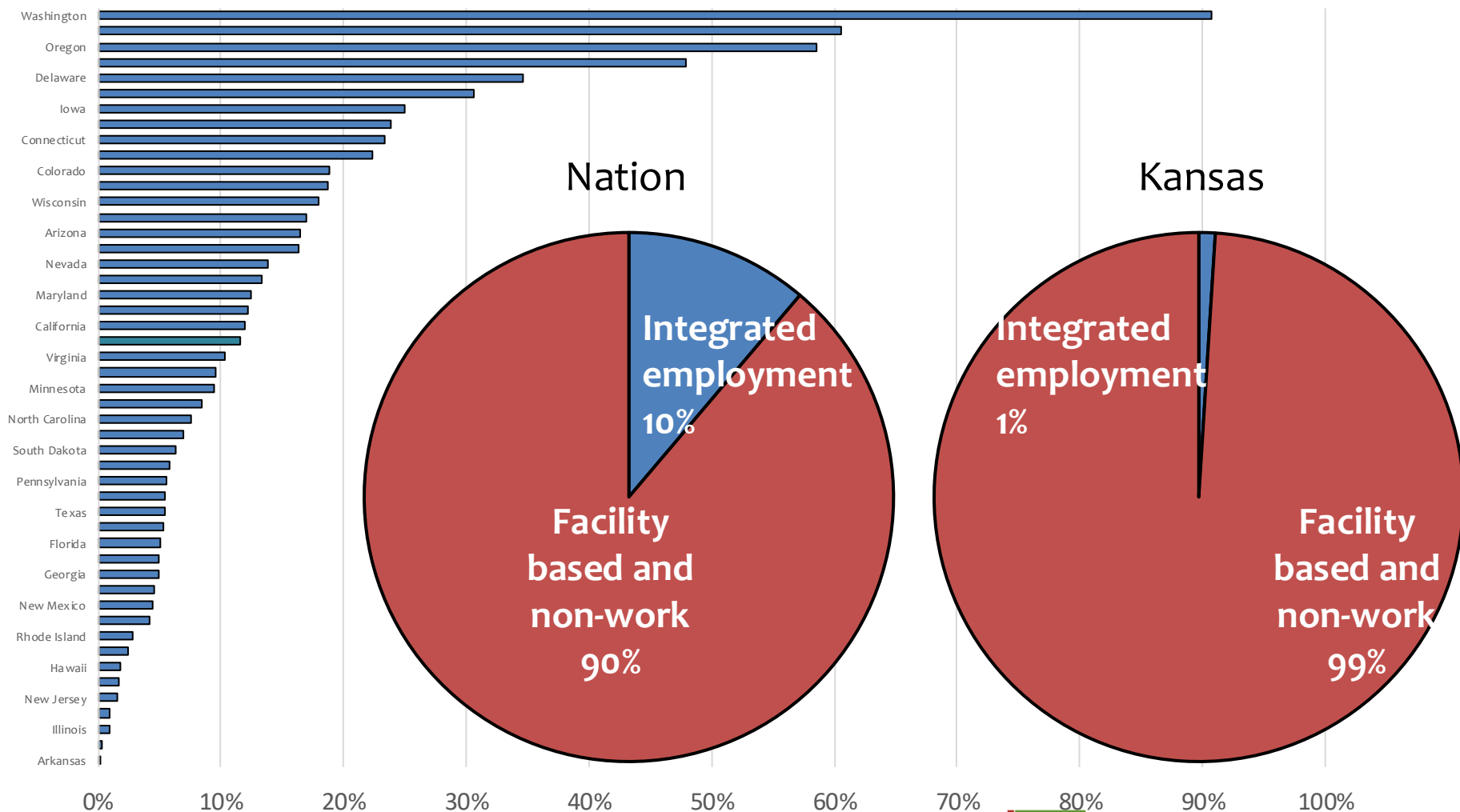
Percent in Integrated Employment Services



Source: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agencies

Financing

Percent of funding that is integrated employment - 2023



Source: ICI National Survey of State IDD Agencies FY2023

Role of case managers: Nation

Do not have a job



Have a job



84% Don't have a job

Want a job



41% with no job want a job

Have a goal



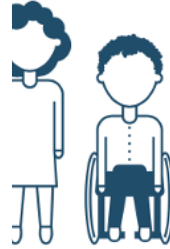
37% who want a job have a goal

Role of case managers: Kansas

Do not have a job



Have a job



85% Don't have a job

Want a job



35% with no job want a job

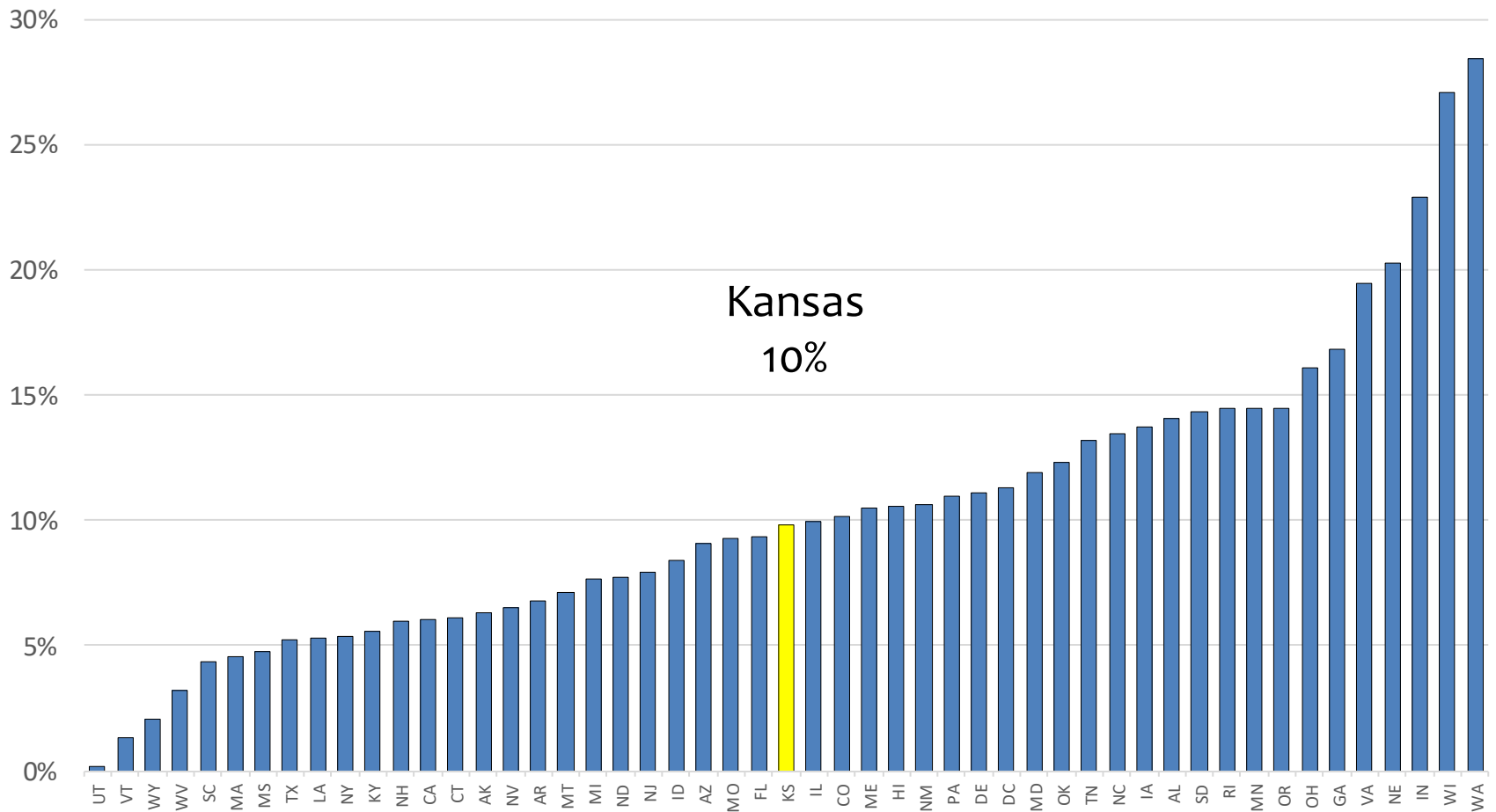
Have a goal



15% who want a job have a goal

Rehabilitation Services

Percent of Closures with an ID 2024

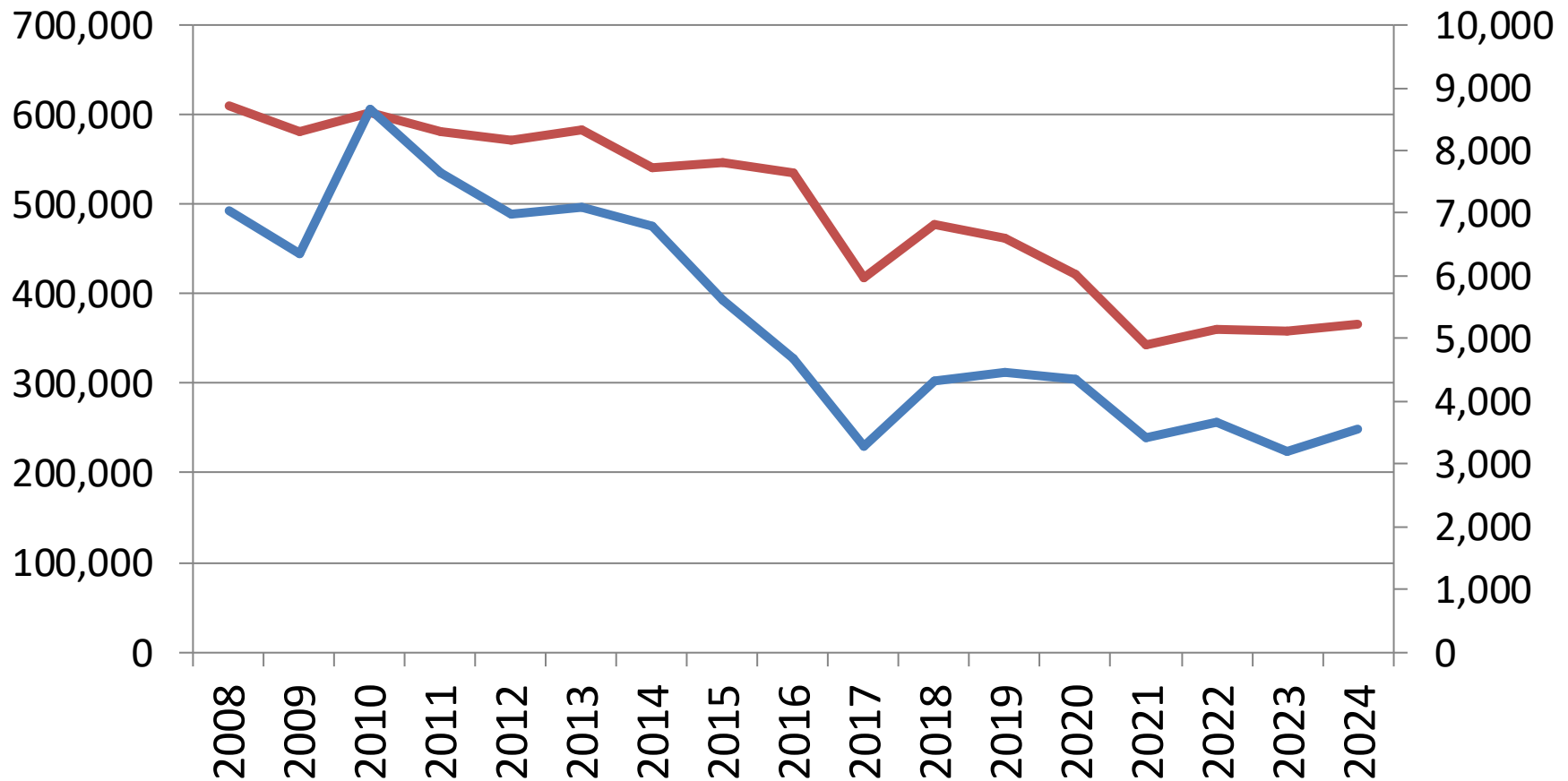


Source: RSA 911

Total VR closures

All closures

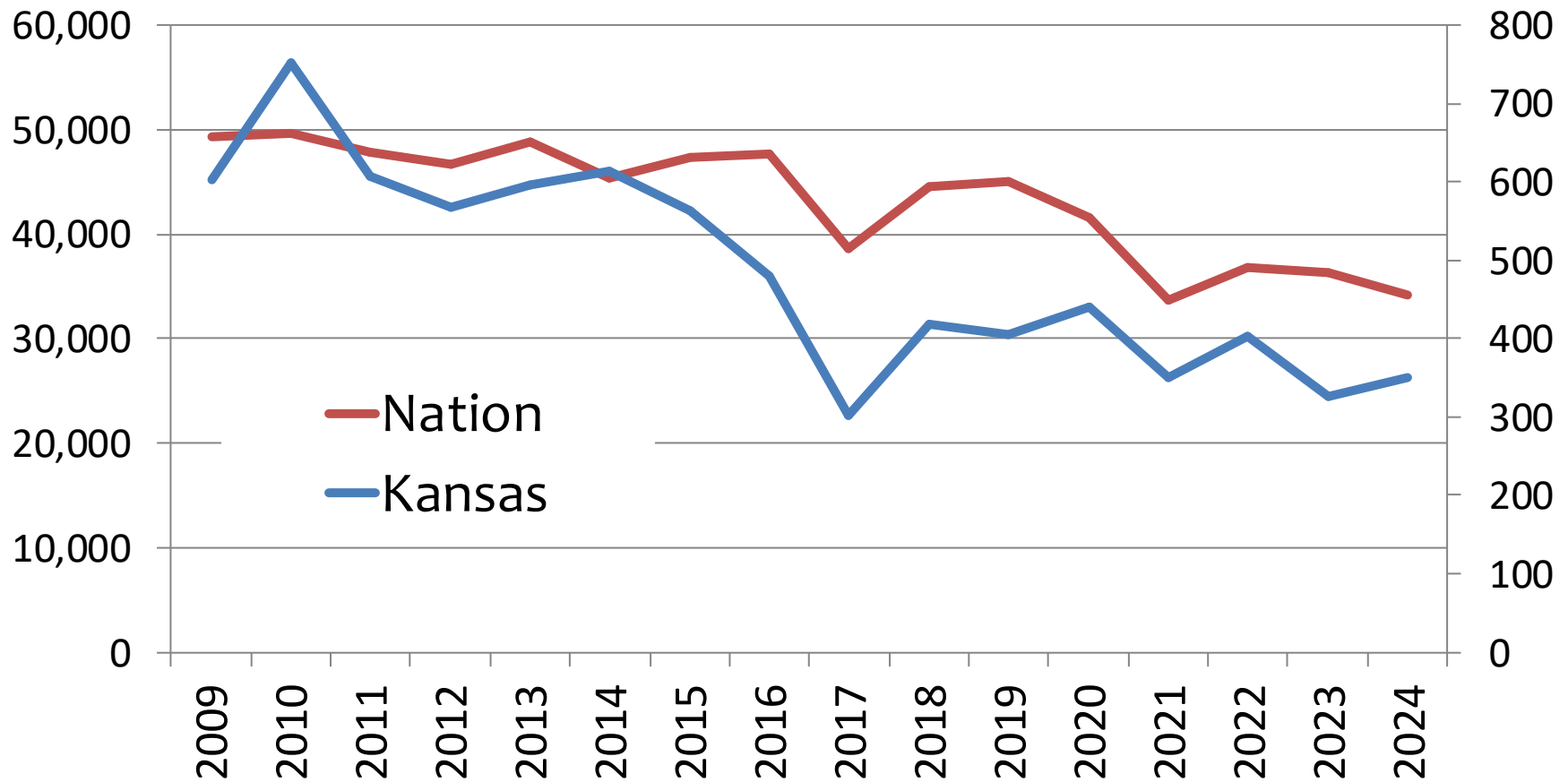
– Nation
– Kansas



Source: RSA 911

Total VR closures

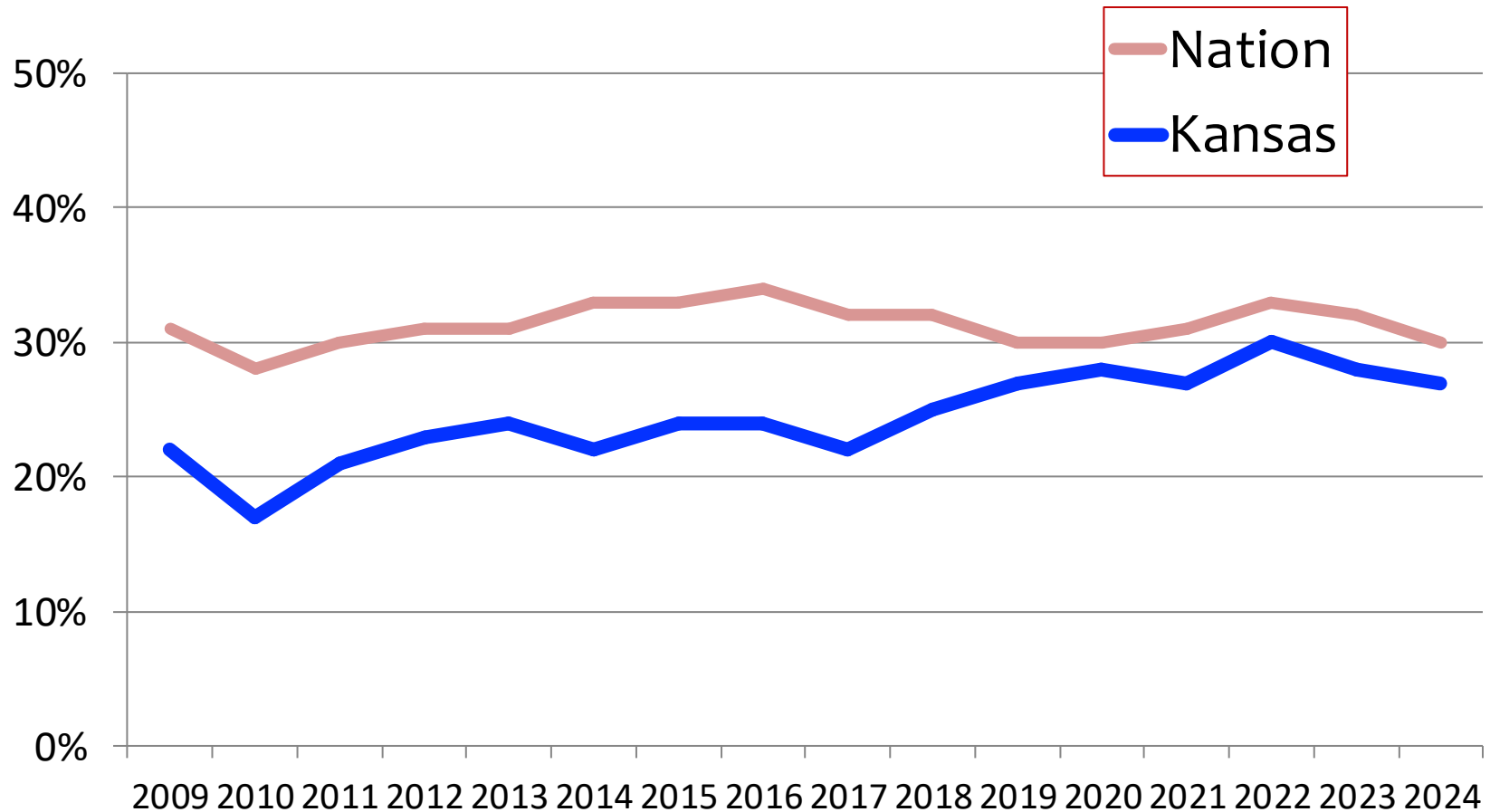
Persons with an ID



Source: RSA 911

Percent of VR closures into employment

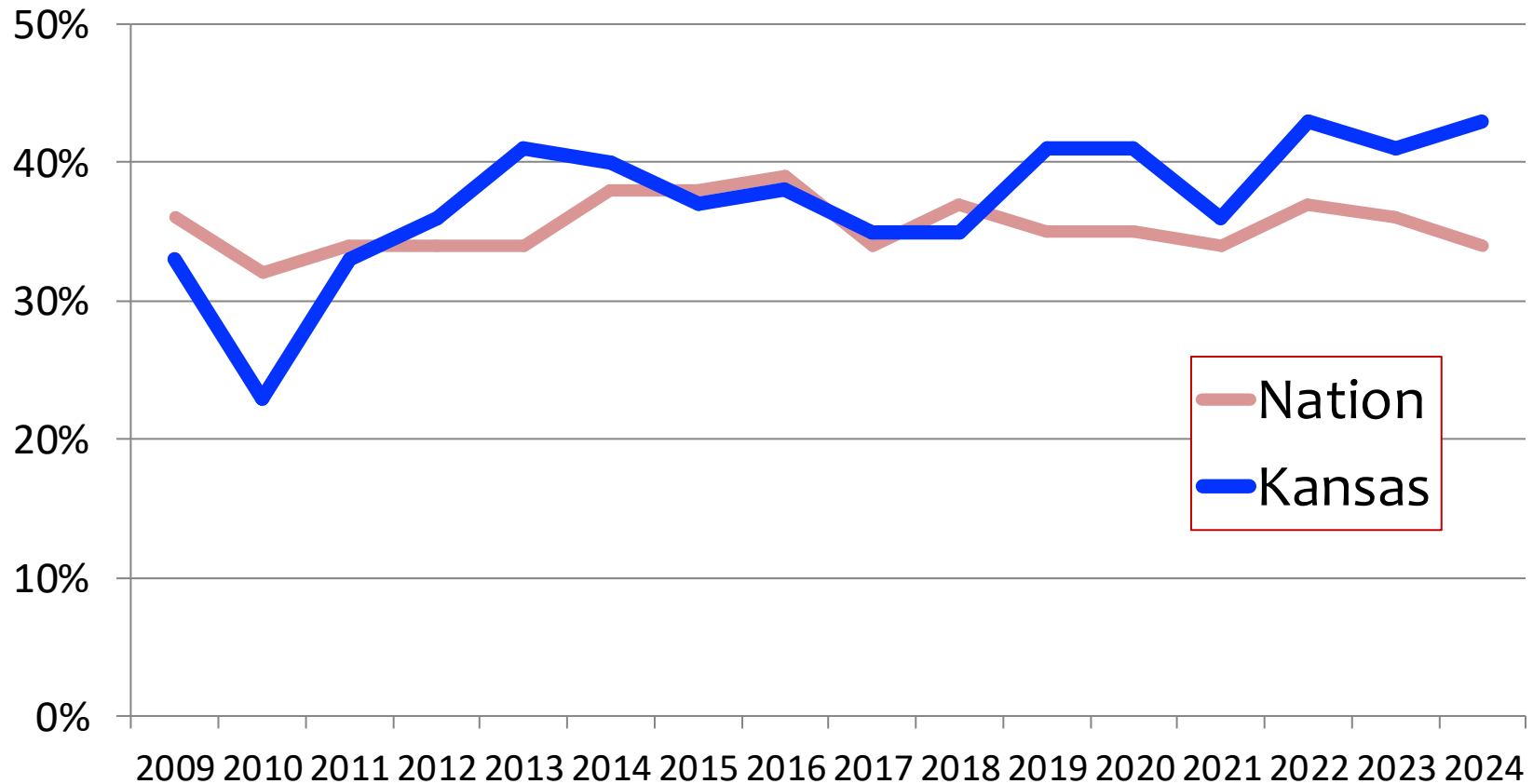
All closures



Source: RSA 911

Percent of VR closures into employment

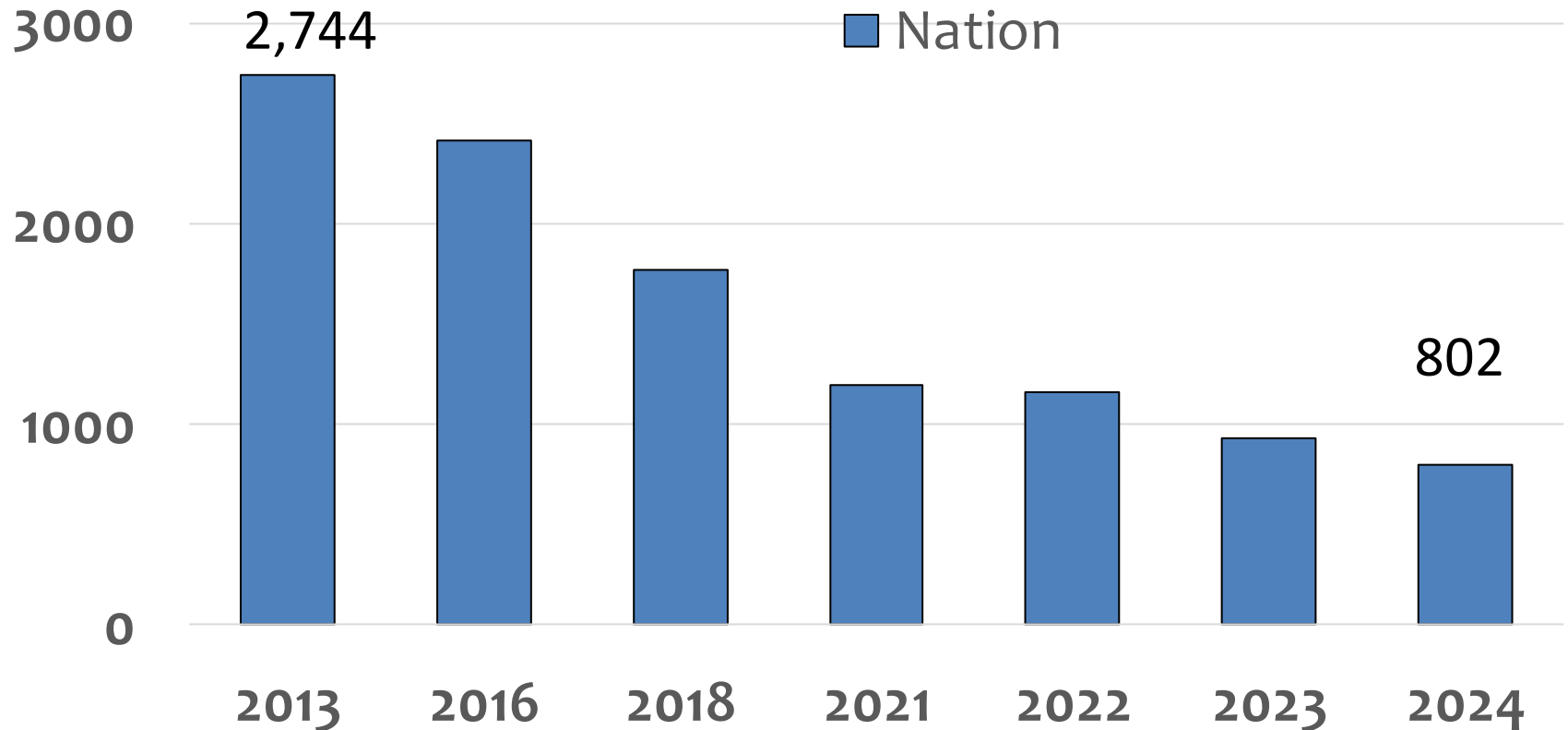
Persons with an ID



Source: RSA 911

Employment under 14(c) certificates

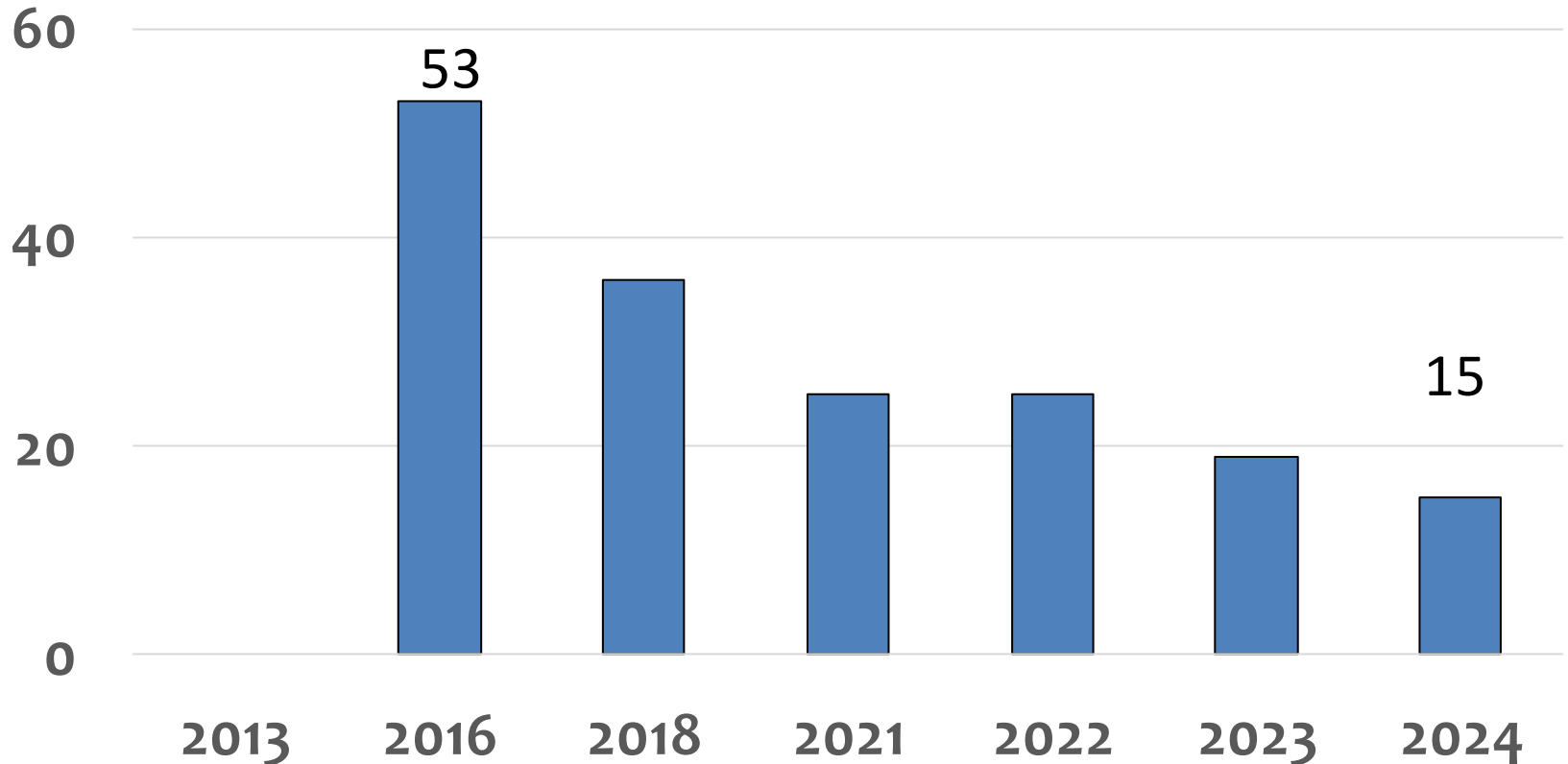
14c Certificates: Nation



Source: US Department of Labor

Source: DOL Certificate Holder List May 2024

14c Certificates: Kansas

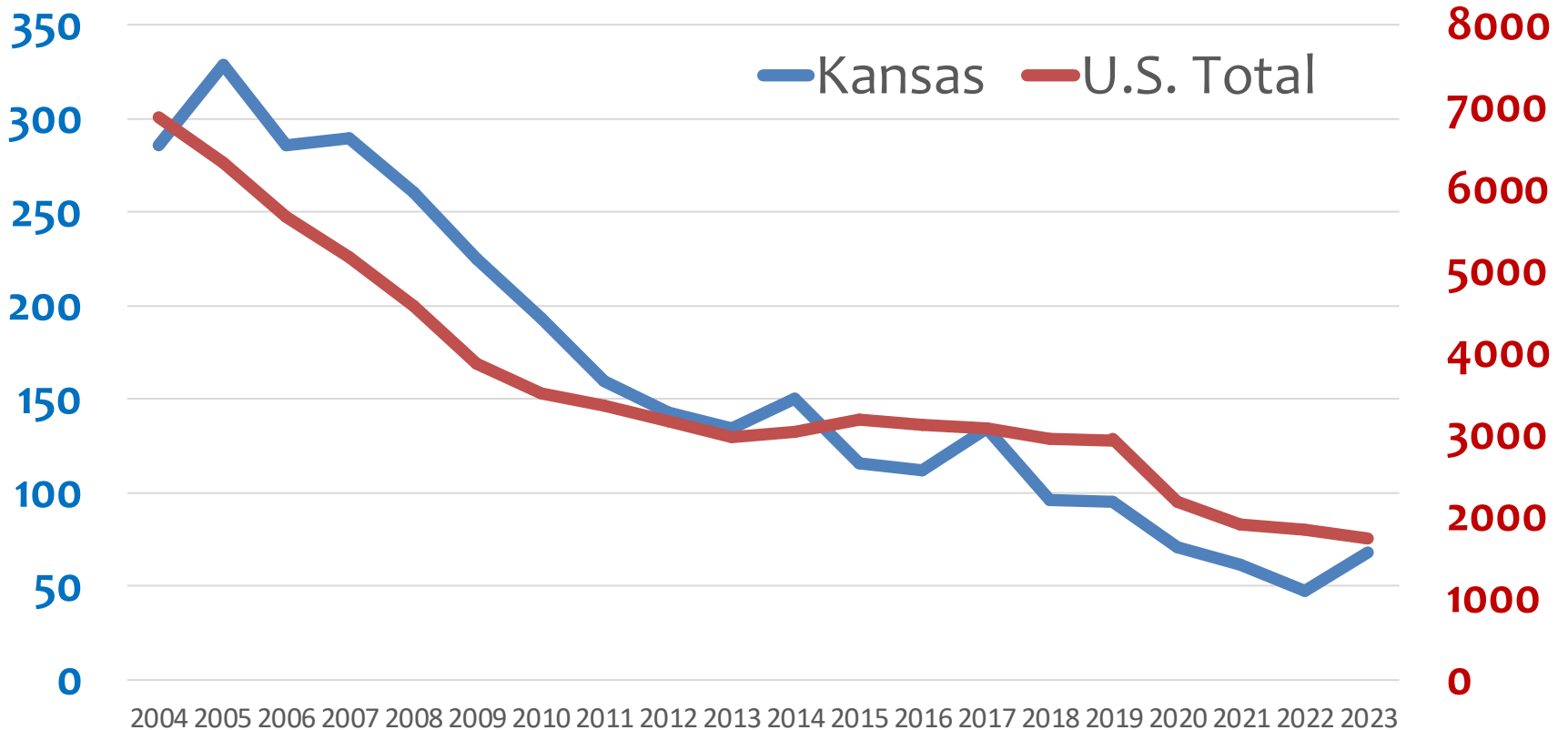


Source: US Department of Labor

Source: DOL Certificate Holder List May 2024

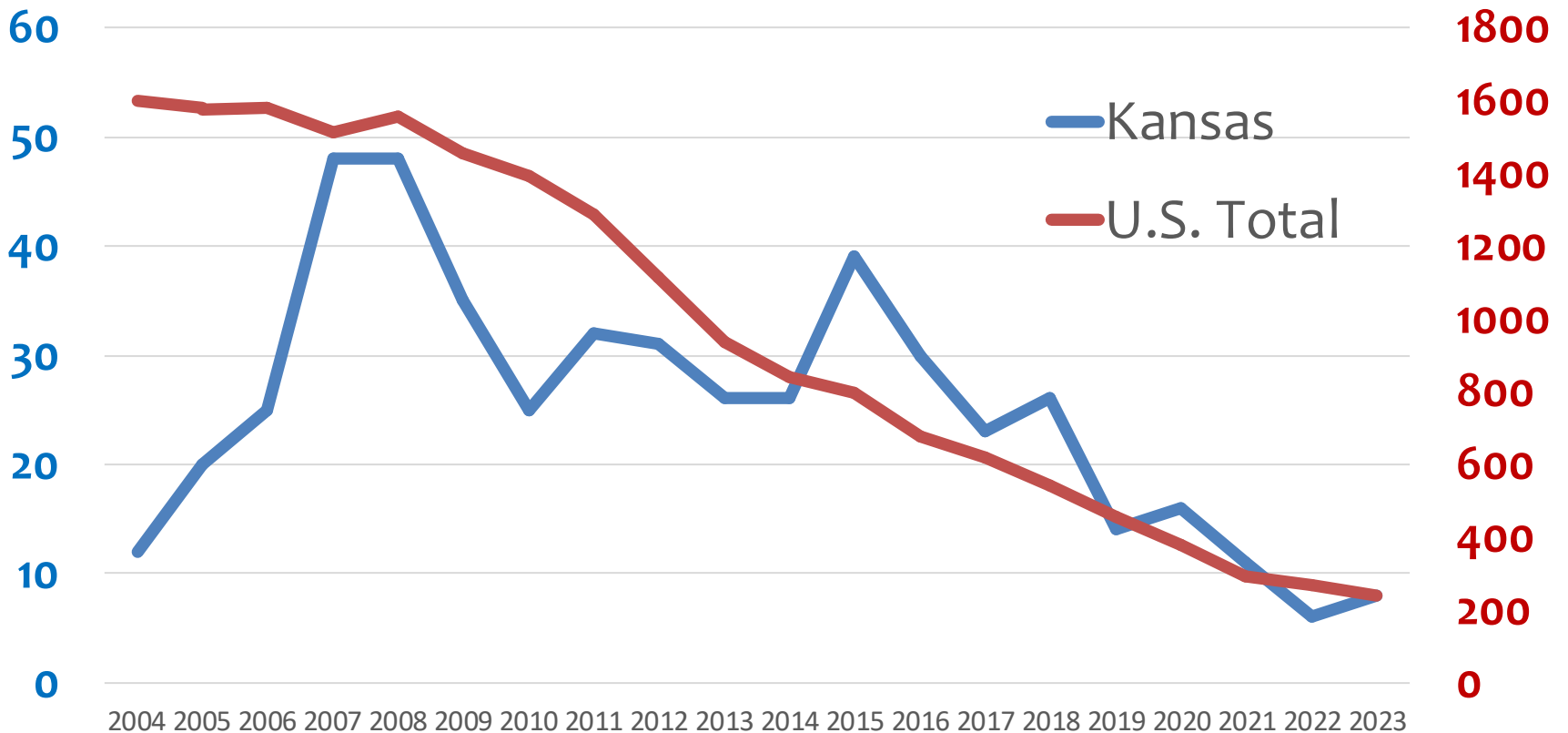
Work Incentives Use

IRWE



Source: SSA

PASS Plans



Source: SSA